Same Gatekeepers, New Gateway

AI Agents, Monopoly Power, and Democratic Risk



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Glossary of Terms

Accelerated Mobile Pages (AMP)	An open-source website structure framework released and maintained by Google, optimized for website display within Google Search results.
Agent Harness	The software wrapped around an LLM that lets it act as an agent. It runs the loop that gives the model its context, carries out the tool calls the model requests (like running code, searching the web, or editing files), and returns the results so the model can decide its next step. It also manages memory, enforces permissions and safety checks, and determines when the task is done. An agent's capability depends on the harness as much as on the underlying model.
Agentic Commerce Protocol (ACP)	An open-source protocol for providing merchant catalogue data (product details, inventory, relevant context) for presentation via an AI model or agent, developed and maintained by OpenAI.
AI Agent	Any LLM-based system that can take actions with varying degrees of autonomy, to achieve a goal set by a human user. Technically, an AI agent combines a large language model (LLM) with an agent harness. The LLM supplies the reasoning: it interprets the goal, decides what to do next, and generates text instructions for each step. The agent harness is the software scaffolding that turns an LLM's text outputs into action. It gives the model access to external tools and services (such as web search, code execution, or file systems), executes the tool calls the model requests, and feeds the results back so the model can decide its next move. Repeating this loop is what lets an agent work through multi-step tasks.
Application Programming Interface (API)	An interface enabling a connection between computer programs, not meant for access by human users. An API allows the programmer to define which program components are open for interaction and on what terms.
Inference	Statistical calculations executed by an AI Model to generate outputs in response to prompts.
Large Language Model (LLM)	A type of deep-learning model trained on vast amounts of text to work with natural language across a wide range of tasks. At their core, LLMs are statistical prediction machines: they learn patterns from their training data and generate language by repeatedly predicting the next word (more precisely, the next token) in a sequence. At sufficient scale, and with additional training to follow instructions, this simple objective yields capabilities like reasoning, writing, and coding. Integrated into an agent harness that converts their text output into actions, LLMs become the core engine of agentic AI.
Model Context Protocol (MCP)	An open-source protocol defining how AI models interact with external systems and data sources, released by Anthropic and maintained by Agentic AI Foundation.
Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP)	An open-source protocol for communications between agentic platforms and digital businesses, enabling agents to place orders, released and maintained by Google.

Executive summary

The next AI revolution

AI's growing ability to mimic human speech and thought has disturbed and excited people in equal measure since the public launch of ChatGPT in 2022. AI's ability to act independently promises even further disruption. While still a work in progress, so-called 'AI agents' nevertheless represent something new and powerful.[1]

By carrying out actions on behalf of users and interacting with the world beyond the chat window, these AI systems are a far cry from 2022's ChatGPT. They can send emails, order groceries, book hotels, fill tax forms, summarize the news, and program new software, taking increasingly consequential actions and decisions on people's behalf. Although early stage versions of agents have been in use for several years, Meta's recent introduction of its Muse agent marks the first true mass market product.

Following several unauthorized hacks by AI agents in 2026 — affecting among other institutions the Australian healthcare system, the U.S. Securities and Exchange Commission, and AI company Hugging Face — public awareness of these emerging capabilities has skyrocketed. This has fueled a public debate focused almost entirely on the risk of AI agents going "rogue" and wreaking havoc on human society, including by hacking or disabling critical infrastructure, facilitating use of biological weapons, and even bringing about human extinction.

Yet while such dangers merit serious discussion, they also risk diverting policymakers' attention from another immediate and tangible threat, one that is the core focus of this report. This is the concentration of economic and political power around a handful of agentic gatekeepers, which need not exterminate humanity to cause it great harm. By giving a few corporations the power to shape our information diets, mediate our relationships with businesses and public services, expand their surveillance of our every move, and take a growing number of actions on our behalf, we could end up preserving the veneer of human civilization, while destroying everything that makes it worth protecting in the first place.

Ultimately, we must move away from the false binary that opposes uncertain, existential risks against already existing harms and threats. This simple narrative may benefit firms that wish to shape regulation in their own interests, or delay it to the distant future, but it does not serve those of us concerned about both.

Agency, trust, and conflicts of interest

The term "agent" also points to something more than just technical capability. It implies a relationship of trust: every action handed to an agent represents a transfer of agency from a person to an automated system. Yet while many people are using these technologies based on the assumption that they will reliably act on their behalf, there are good reasons to question this.

The powerful corporations that design and control today's leading AI agents — whether Anthropic, Google, OpenAI, Microsoft, or Meta — are relentlessly focused on furthering their own commercial interests, regardless of whether those coincide with, or even undermine, those of their users. Many of these firms have an extensive track record of surveilling, manipulating, and exploiting their customers for financial — and sometimes political — gain. There is little reason to expect them to behave any differently this time around, particularly given the unprecedented sums these

1 There is an ongoing debate about where to draw the line between AI chatbots, AI assistants, and AI agents. In this report, we use the term 'AI agent' to refer to technologies able to act on behalf of their users, even where they are not labelled as agents by their makers.

corporations have invested in developing advanced AI and the need to recoup those costs, one way or another.

This tension was brought home in early 2026 by a high-profile public debate between Anthropic and OpenAI over whether these corporations should integrate advertising — in any way whatsoever — into the delivery of information by personalized agents. At present, no law prevents providers of personal agents from manipulating actions and recommendations based on the interests of advertisers, or from transferring personal data they collect to other advertising platforms.

Though AI agents are new, the concept of agents is not. For millennia, humans have relied on a broad set of norms and laws to set out the responsibilities of agents; to govern relationships in which one person relies on another to perform a task or service on their behalf. Written in 1753 BC, the Babylonian Code of Hammurabi, one of the oldest sets of laws in the world, carefully regulated the relationship between urban merchants and the agents who transported and sold their goods on their behalf.[2] Its modern descendents include the fiduciary duties that require agents — such as financial advisers and lawyers — to act in the interests of their clients.

Relationships in which people entrust others to act on their behalf, and the rules needed to make that possible, are thus as old as organized human civilization. The challenge today is to ensure that all AI "agents" — and services that promise agent-like outcomes — face the same responsibilities to serve their clients as their human counterparts.

AI agents and concentration of power

Competition among corporations training, releasing, and selling access to AI foundation models has been extensively studied and debated. Though the market and technology is still in flux, it is clear that only a small number of actors with access to enormous capital, compute, data, and highly skilled human resources are able to compete at the frontier. Close behind that frontier, in large part thanks to open-weight models from China, there is increasing evidence that the broader model market is becoming commoditized.[3]

There has been much less study however of how the AI agents and assistants being built atop these models will affect the structure of the digital economy. This report starts to fill that gap.

Despite the fact that we have witnessed the rise to power of several new corporations such as OpenAI and Anthropic, other factors are working together to drive the already highly consolidated market for both digital services broadly and AI agents specifically towards further concentration.

First, as model capabilities converge, competitive differentiation is shifting towards distribution and integration. Today's tech giants, thanks to their monopoly control of search engines, operating systems, browsers, social media platforms, and other gateway technologies, have an unparalleled ability to put their AI products in front of billions of people, and in some cases even to compel their use.

Second, data from user interactions with AI agents is likely to play a key role in product development and service quality, creating a possible first-mover advantage whereby the corporations that secure an early lead stay ahead thanks to the extensive and highly personalized data their growing user base provides them with.

Third, network effects have the potential to play a significant role as developers, online merchants, publishers, and creators become more dependent — whether through commercial agreements or technical integration — on the most popular agents to reach

2 Johnston, 'Natural Law and the Fiduciary Duties of Business Managers'.

3 Evans, 'Ways to Think about Token Pricing'; Fasano et al., 'GLM-5.3 and the Spread of Advanced Cyber Capabilities'.

customers and citizens, drawing even more users to those agents and accelerating market consolidation.

Further, already dominant corporations will inevitably exploit their existing powers and advantages to accelerate concentration of power and control into their own hands. This includes tactics such as making it difficult for users to switch agents by limiting interoperability and data portability, and acquiring or co-opting nascent competitors that could offer people alternative agents.

Risks from concentration of power and control over AI agents

The question of control over AI agents is also a question of power over the individual. It is about who owns the gateways through which human intention must pass to become action in the world. When you ask Google Search a question, you still have to click, compare, evaluate, and decide. When you book a flight through Expedia, you pick from multiple options. When you browse Amazon, you have the impression, at least, of browsing and choosing from the choices presented.

The introduction of the AI agent threatens to take away even this limited agency. It does not present options so much as it selects them. It does not surface information so much as it filters, synthesizes and interprets it. The corporations that control the agent can shape, in a very real sense, the user's sense and experience of reality: what they buy, how they learn and understand, what they believe to be possible or impossible.

One of the main lessons of the last 15 to 20 years is that the more concentrated the market, the more concentrated and invasive the manipulation of the individual. Over this period, dominant corporations such as Google and Meta used their monopoly control of advertising, search, social media, and other services and technologies not only to concentrate greater power and further extend their reach, but also to radically increase their ability to surveil, manipulate, and exploit both individuals and businesses.

As explained by Sally Hubbard in a recent Open Markets Institute report, "Who do AI Agents Work For?":

"Big Tech platforms were the first internet middlemen, separating readers from publishers (Google and Facebook), buyers from sellers (Amazon), and fans from artists and content creators (YouTube and Spotify), and then intermediating those relationships. The result has been the destruction of journalism and the degradation of the entire political economy of information, highly targeted manipulation of the citizenry and individuals, increasingly sophisticated and effective extraction of wealth from individual people and small and mid-sized companies, and ever more extreme concentration of economic and political power in the hands of a few."[4]

We should not assume that concentrated control of AI agents will do anything other than make every one of these problems more acute, particularly given that most of the same dominant corporations are involved. Indeed, the scale of surveillance, manipulation, and exploitation is likely to be far worse than we have seen thus far. The anthropomorphic design of AI agents, their access to unprecedented amounts of personal data, and their ability to both recommend and directly act "on behalf" of users, as opposed to merely displaying information, will not only cut the individual out of the decision chain today but over time will likely degrade the ability of individuals to compare alternatives, control different facets of their own lives, and make coherent decisions.

These dangers are further amplified by the integration of agents into existing products and services that are themselves based on centralized control, value extraction, and behavioral manipulation, which, as we detail in this report, is already happening at speed.

Centralized control over AI agents poses many threats to our societies, our economies, and our democracies. These include:

4 Hubbard, 'Who Do AI Agents Work For?'

Societal and political harms

- **Further centralization of control over news and information flows and production,** underpinned by unprecedented and sustained access to personal data, that gives one or a few corporations the ability to shape what information individuals receive and how it is presented to them, creating widespread opportunities for direct and indirect influence and manipulation;
- **Further damage to journalism and the creative industries** as AI agents accelerate the disconnection between publishers/creators and consumers, weakening the revenue streams and access to readers and viewers that sustain creation of independent content and undermining fair conditions for creators;
- **Widespread and extensive corporate surveillance** as centralized AI agents collect and combine unprecedented amounts of personal data, from browsing history and text messages to online payments and location data, and use this to manipulate their users;
- **State capture and the undermining of sovereignty** as governments become increasingly dependent on a handful of AI firms, allowing those firms (and their owners) to exploit this dependence to influence government policy, leading to the weaponization of concentrated AI infrastructure and capabilities against foreign states;
- **Atomization and homogenization of the public** as individuals become isolated by their interactions with AI systems, and as the homogeneity of AI outputs and actions suppresses the diversity of tastes, preferences, and perspectives that together make up a pluralistic society.

Economic harms

- **Acceleration of surveillance pricing and manipulation** as AI agents with access to unprecedented amounts of personal data — including on people's finances, health, and emotional states — use this data to extract as much value as they can from consumers, including by raising prices to the maximum an individual will pay, and signing them up for subscriptions, add-ons, and other features they don't truly need.
- **Unprecedented concentration of gatekeeper power** as agentic AI becomes the main gateway to the internet, giving one or a few corporations extreme power over interactions between buyers and sellers across broad swathes of the economy, which they can use to capture more value, impose exploitative terms and conditions, steal valuable ideas, and concentrate ever greater power over the individuals and businesses who depend on these platforms to get to market;
- **Market steering and self-preferencing** as the firms controlling AI agents use them to direct people to their own services or those of commercial partners, accelerating concentration of power while undermining transparency, fairness, and individual autonomy across the economy;
- **Algorithmic collusion** as a concentrated market makes collusion between AI agents easier and thus more likely to occur, creating new opportunities for manipulation and value extraction;
- **Centralized points of failure** as a society built on the infrastructure of one or a few agentic systems become vulnerable to any form of failure, disruption, or successful attack on that infrastructure;
- **Correlated agent behavior** as similar or identical agents respond identically and rapidly to external shocks — for instance, in financial markets or during a health emergency — in unhelpful or dangerous ways, disrupting economic and societal stability.

Early days, avoidable threats, new tools

The market for agentic AI is still young. This does not mean that we should wait and see how it develops before acting: today's highly concentrated digital markets have shown the shortfalls of that approach.

Importantly, agentic AI is emerging in a very different environment from the one in which today's tech monopolies were born. Unlike the upstarts of the early internet, today's Big Tech corporations have unprecedented power to shape the development of new technologies, including agentic AI. They do so, of course, in ways that suit their own private interests over the wider public interest. This is not a free market by any reasonable interpretation of the term.

At the same time, the political and regulatory environment has also changed dramatically, in this case largely for the better. Policymakers have become much more attuned to the harms of concentrated tech power and have taken concrete action to address them. These include landmark antitrust investigations on Big Tech dominance in Europe, the United States, Canada, Brazil, India, and other jurisdictions. It also includes powerful new regulatory tools including the EU's Digital Markets Act, Digital Services Act and AI Act, the UK's Digital Markets, Competition and Consumers Act, Japan's Mobile Software Competition Act, and Australia's News Media Bargaining Code, to name just a few.

While still early days, this more robust approach to enforcement has already begun bearing fruit. This includes two separate U.S. court rulings charging Google with illegal monopolization (albeit while failing to impose remedies matching the scale of the harm),[5] the prevention of several harmful tech mergers (including Nvidia-Arm,[6] Meta-Giphy,[7] and Amazon-iRobot),[8] and, in Europe, significant business model changes including the availability of alternative app stores on the iPhone, choice screens on Apple iOS and Google Android, and interoperability between different messaging services. More significant than any specific regulatory measure, however, is an underlying shift in philosophy beyond the narrow price-focused paradigm that undermined effective enforcement for decades.

Governments must now proactively build on these advances, instead of being blindsided yet again by the novelty of emerging technologies. With robust and timely policy interventions, agentic AI could still take a very different trajectory to the monopolistic status quo of today's digital economy and the dystopian future that too many feel is inevitable. Through a combination of law enforcement, smart regulation, pro-competitive standards, and robust competition enforcement, it is not too late to turn agentic AI, and AI as a whole, into a technology that supports democracy, shared prosperity, and human dignity, instead of one that only deepens our extreme dependence on a handful of tech monopolies.

This points us towards three overarching types of action to take:

Ensuring agents act in the interests of their users, not their owners

- Impose fiduciary-style duties to pre-empt conflicts of interest and ensure agents' behaviors remain aligned with their users' interests

5 U.S. Department of Justice Office of Public Affairs, Department of Justice Wins Significant Remedies Against Google; U.S. Department of Justice Office of Public Affairs, *Department of Justice Again Wins Substantial Relief Against Google.*

6 Palma et al., 'US Regulator Sues to Stop Nvidia's Acquisition of Arm'.

7 Sweney, 'Facebook Owner Meta to Sell Giphy after UK Watchdog Confirms Ruling'.

8 Mattioli and Mackrael, 'Amazon, iRobot Abandon Deal Amid Regulatory Scrutiny'.

- Regulate AI agents in ways effectively equivalent to their human counterparts, creating comparable regulation for comparable activities
- Restrict invasive and unjustified surveillance, both by enforcing existing laws and by developing new ones where necessary

Steering agentic AI towards an open and decentralized future

- Mandate vertical interoperability to ensure that third-party businesses are able to integrate with AI agents on fair terms
- Require horizontal interoperability and data portability to ensure that users, whether businesses or individuals, are able to easily switch between different agents
- Mandate fair, reasonable, and non-discriminatory access to both agents themselves and the digital infrastructure and platforms that agents rely on
- Create regimes for independent third-party certification to ensure that standards are set, monitored and enforced by neutral public bodies instead of private gatekeepers

Using competition policy to prevent consolidation and (re)shape markets in the public interest

- Prevent and punish anti-competitive practices across the AI "stack"
- Block mergers and partnerships that undermine fair competition among AI agents and across the wider stack
- Use structural remedies to mitigate conflicts of interest that arise when the same firm is vertically integrated across the technology stack
- Monitor for algorithmic collusion, and sanction it when uncovered

Introduction

The agentic frontier

After several years of rapid technological development in AI, today's dominant tech corporations and leading AI firms are racing to develop a technology that promises to entirely remake the internet as we have known it: AI "agents." As conceived by these corporations, AI agents herald an exciting new era in which every human can enjoy the services of personalized, automated assistants capable of everything from answering our emails and booking our appointments to finding us the cheapest flights and completing our tax forms for us.

Yet, even if agentic AI does deliver many or most of these promised benefits, it also risks worsening today's already extreme levels of concentrated power and control over digital markets and communications infrastructure. Most of the agentic technologies being developed and commercialized today are built atop foundation models and cloud infrastructure owned by a few powerful corporations — Google, Amazon, Microsoft, Meta, in particular — that have also monopolized access to data, computing power, talent, and capital.

These same gatekeepers are now using agentic technologies to boost their already extreme capacity to exploit and coerce the individuals, businesses, and governments who depend on their services, infrastructure, and technologies.

Indeed, viewed broadly, agentic AI is already beginning to exacerbate many of the other economic, political, and societal disruptions created by the business models and behaviors of these corporations.[9] The introduction of AI and chatbots into search and other online services has started to transform the way people communicate

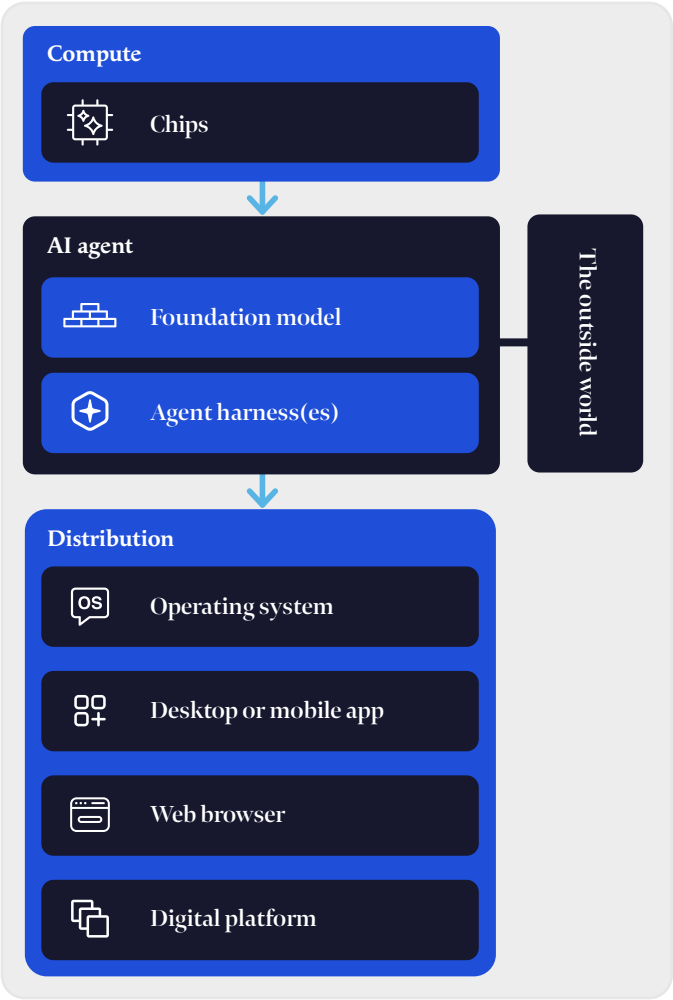


Figure 1: The simplified agentic AI stack

and interact in the market, creating new opportunities and methods for behavioral manipulation while also further disrupting the ability of businesses that depend on an open internet to reach their customers and compete on fair terms. This includes not only every independent retailer but also independent publishers, with devastating implications for public debate, local community, and democratic governance.

9 Lynn, *Cornered: The New Monopoly Capitalism and the Economics of Destruction*; Lynn, *Liberty from All Masters*.

Democratic societies must urgently find answers to two foundational questions. First, how can we ensure that agents act in the interests of their users rather than their corporate owners or other powerful actors, including states? Second, how can governments structure the market for AI agents and AI more generally to limit centralization of power and maximize safety, choice, innovation, and democratic accountability? This report aims to provide answers.

AI agents: a primer

What is an AI Agent?

Defined technically, an AI agent is any foundation model-based system that can take goal-directed actions with varying degrees of autonomy.[10] This encompasses an extremely wide and diverse range of technologies and products.[11] This report focuses on the one likely to have the widest adoption and pose the greatest set of risks to our economies and democracies: general-purpose agentic AI assistants.[12]

Today's AI agents are built by combining a large language model (LLM) with an agent harness. The LLM supplies the reasoning: it interprets the goal, decides what to do next, and generates text instructions for each step. The agent harness is the software scaffolding that turns an LLM's text outputs into action. It gives the model access to external tools and services (such as web search, code execution, third party applications, or file systems), executes the tool calls the model requests, and feeds the results back so the model can decide its next move. Repeating this loop is what lets an agent work through multi-step tasks.

General-purpose agentic AI assistants are the most visible products associated with the AI boom and include the likes of OpenAI's ChatGPT, Anthropic's Claude, Google's Gemini, Meta's Muse, and Microsoft's Copilot. These systems build foundation LLMs into consumer-facing interfaces capable of accessing and using external tools and services. Their goal is to become the interface through which people access and interact with the digital world — a new universal digital intermediary.[13]

The term "AI agent" evokes connotations of autonomy, efficiency, and reliability. This makes it a powerful rhetorical tool: one that helps generative AI developers market their products by claiming they possess capabilities for independent judgement and action that they currently do not, and may never, possess.

At the same time, it describes something genuinely new and powerful: AI systems that carry out actions on behalf of users. Rather than simply returning answers to prompts, these products can now interact with the world beyond the chat window. This includes triaging and responding to emails, planning and booking trips, and ordering groceries — all without the user opening their inbox, an airline's website, or a supermarket's app.

We use the term "AI agent" to refer to all technologies that can take action on behalf of their users, regardless of whether they are labeled as such by their developers and owners. Our understanding of and response to new technologies must be based on their actual capabilities, not on how they are labeled and marketed.

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10 These systems are not autonomous in any strong sense. Rather, they pursue user-defined goals through iterative tool use within human-defined constraints and environments.

11 We adopt programmer Simon Willison's concrete definition of AI agents: 'An LLM agent runs tools in a loop to achieve a goal' in Willison, 'I Think "Agent" May Finally Have a Widely Enough Agreed upon Definition to Be Useful Jargon Now'.

12 Throughout the report we use the terms 'agentic AI', 'AI agents', and 'AI assistants' to refer to agentic AI assistants.

13 Farmer et al., 'The Dilemmas of Delegation'.

A universal digital intermediary

The executives of today's largest tech firms have grandiose ambitions for their AI agents. Beyond navigating users' digital lives and taking action on their behalf,[14] some want to build a "personal superintelligence (...) that can see what we see, hear what we hear";[15] a "model (...) that you put your whole life into."[16] Others want to create a technology that people use to "be better versions of themselves"[17] but also one designed to "make people addicted" and upon which they "depend on daily."[18] The ultimate goal that unites these visions is to become the basic interface through which people access and interact with the digital world — a universal digital intermediary.[19]

The appeal of an AI agent or assistant is undeniable: it promises to save people significant time and effort in accessing and interacting with digital information and services. Agentic assistants can eliminate the need to navigate to news articles, write content, compare product reviews, select and pay for online purchases, or peruse booking platforms to make reservations. Rather than direct users towards external information or services, agents retrieve and summarize information, complete purchases and draft communications, all through a unified interface. This increasingly seamless user experience reduces "friction," saving time and lowering the cognitive burden of navigating a fragmented digital environment.

Yet this convenience also heralds a deeper and potentially permanent structural shift. As more activity is mediated through a small number of general purpose AI agents, these systems could become centralized gateways through which people access information, services, and markets. The result would yet another form of centralized market power and intermediation, in which agentic assistants increasingly stand between people

"Personal superintelligence that knows us deeply [...] that understand our context because they can see what we see, hear what we hear, and interact with us throughout the day"

— Mark Zuckerberg, Meta CEO

"...your personal AI agent in Gemini app that helps you navigate your digital life, taking action on your behalf and under your direction."

— Sundar Pichai, Google CEO

"a model [...] you put your whole life into. This model can reason across your whole context and do it efficiently. And every conversation you've ever had in your life, every book you've ever read, every email you've ever read, everything you've ever looked at is in there, plus connected to all your data from other sources."

— Sam Altman, OpenAI

"Make people addicted [...] grow the user base, and build the skill and tool ecosystem that makes people depend on it daily"

— Microsoft (internal),
"Claw Pilot: Overview and Plan with Project Lobster"

Figure 2: Big Tech executives' visions for AI agents

14 Google, 'I/O 2026'.

15 Meta, 'Personal Superintelligence'.

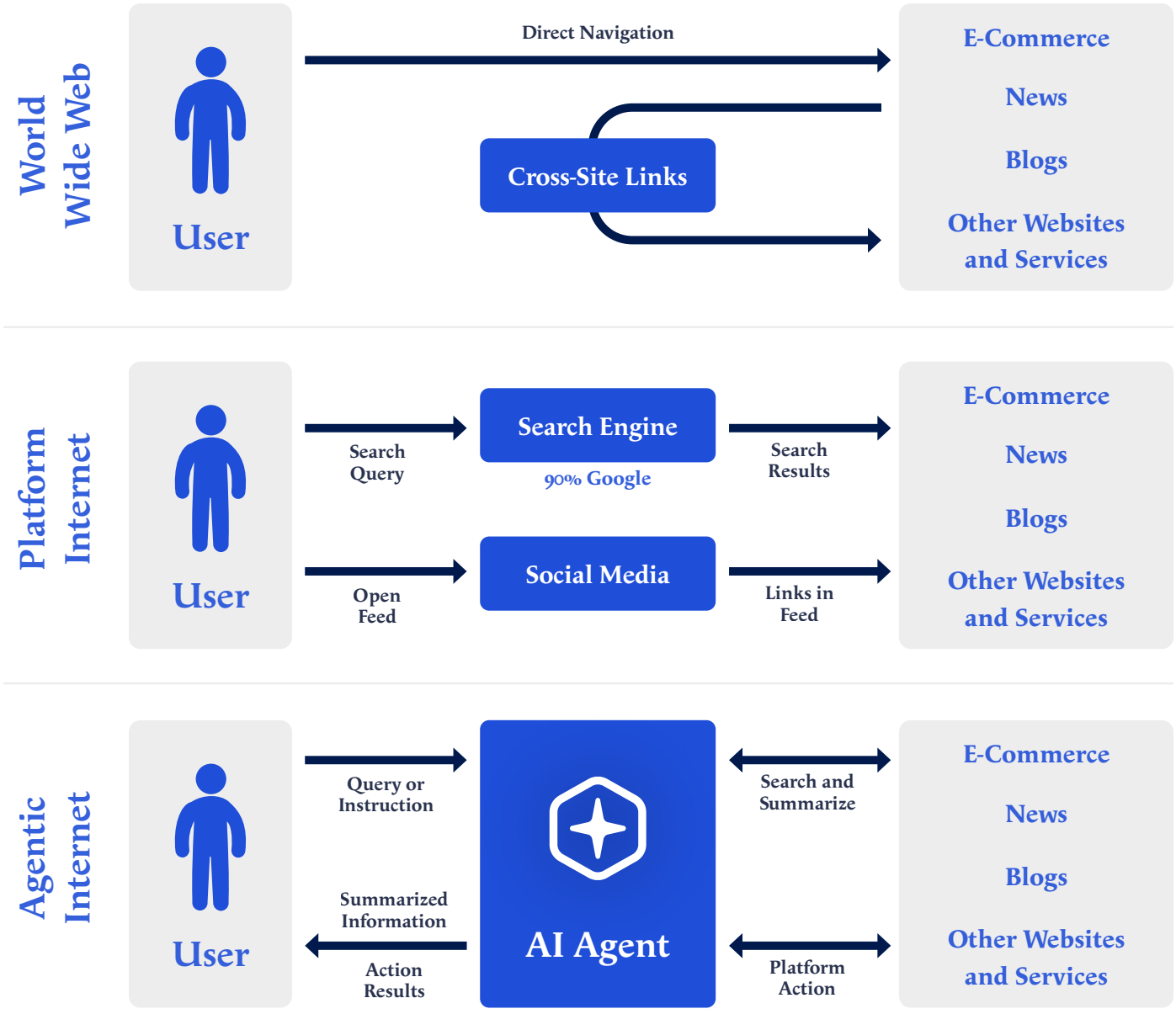
16 Bort, 'Sam Altman's Goal for ChatGPT to Remember "your Whole Life" Is Both Exciting and Disturbing'.

17 Warren, 'Microsoft Scout Is "the First Real Personal Assistant We've Offered Customers"'.

18 Koebler and Maiberg, 'Microsoft Wants to "Make People Addicted" to Its New AI Assistant, Internal Documents Reveal'.

19 Farmer et al., 'The Dilemmas of Delegation'.

Figure 3: An increasingly intermediated internet



and the open web. Because agentic assistants will likely become increasingly difficult to opt out of as more and more services and customers rely on them to reach each other, these gatekeepers may become unavoidable.

The commercial rationale for providing agentic intermediation is clear. Whoever controls these gateways will have immense power over those that depend on them to access the digital world, including the ability to manipulate, coerce, and extort people, businesses, and even governments. Ensuring we have the policies in place to limit this concentration of power in the first place, and to govern the power that remains, must be our central priority.

The limits of the scaling paradigm

During the initial phase of the AI boom, the industry's focus was overwhelmingly on model scale. Big Tech corporations and leading AI labs believed — or hoped — that making models more powerful by training them on ever more data and compute would by itself lead to hyper-capable AI systems. However, diminishing returns from

simply adding more data and compute to model training,[20] combined with the unsustainable costs of running high-performance models and the pressing commercial need to create useful products that people will pay for, has changed the picture. The dream of autonomous general purpose AI agents remains, but it now relies on a much more complex and diverse array of technical innovations.

These innovations include architectural breakthroughs, grounding model responses in verified external sources, increasing the compute allocated to inference (calculations executed by AI models to generate outputs), making models "reason" for longer and more extensively, breaking complex tasks into chains of smaller steps (iterative reasoning),[21] and handling these smaller steps using specialized sub-models working in parallel.[22] As well as improving general performance, these innovations help improve agentic capabilities by selecting the appropriate tools the AI system needs to use in order to execute tasks (a web browser for web search, or a calendar app for planning meetings),[23] and by validating outputs before delivering a final result.[24]

Google, OpenAI, and several other firms spent much of 2025 attempting to create viable agents by building them into browsers. Under this approach, agentic assistants are given the tools to control the browser itself, allowing them to navigate to websites, click buttons, fill in forms, and extract information akin to human users. Despite some successes, these systems struggle with the unstructured, unstandardized, and often poorly designed nature of the open web.[25] This has turned standardization into a battleground for influence and control.

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20 Patel, 'Ilya Sutskever — We're Moving from the Age of Scaling to the Age of Research'.

21 Ma et al., 'Inference-Time Scaling for Diffusion Models beyond Scaling Denoising Steps'; Rawat et al., 'Pre-Act'.

22 Gutowska, 'What Is a Multi-Agent System?'

23 Stryker, 'What Is Tool Calling?'

24 Hond et al., 'From Text to Treatment'.

25 Song, 'One Day, AI Might Be Better than You at Surfing the Web. That Day Isn't Today.'

To advertise or not to advertise? The heated debate over AI ads

In February 2026, OpenAI introduced advertising to ChatGPT. This was despite its CEO Sam Altman previously referring to ads in AI services as "uniquely disturbing." The decision prompted the departure of OpenAI researcher Zoë Hitzig, who penned a New York Times op-ed warning of the unprecedented manipulation risks of AI-fueled advertising.[26] She compared OpenAI to Facebook, which two decades ago similarly abandoned its commitments on user privacy in favor of advertising revenues.

In response to the news, rival Anthropic, which does not currently include advertising in its products, seized the opportunity to portray its Claude agent as "acting unambiguously in our users' interests,"[27] including producing a series of commercials mocking AI advertising that aired during the Superbowl. This led to a boost in Anthropic's reputation and visibility, including an uptick in subscriptions.[28] AI-powered search engine Perplexity also abandoned advertising in early 2026, stating that advertising in AI assistants is incompatible with user trust.[29]

Google, for its part, has shown far fewer reservations about combining advertising and AI. Ads are already integrated into AI Overviews and Ad Mode, although Gemini remains ad-free (for now). Meta's new AI agent Muse does not currently include ads, although given that advertising is the basis of Meta's business model, this may not be the case for long. Both Meta and Google are also aggressively pushing advertisers to use AI tools when designing and placing ads on their social media and search platforms.

The inclusion of advertising in AI assistants and agents raises serious concerns about conflicts of interest. How can an AI agent funded by advertising be trusted to provide reliable information about a product or service, when that product or service may well belong to one of those advertisers? More generally, can advertising-funded AI systems be counted on to provide information or take actions in the user's best interest, or will they simply seek to maximize immediate profit and long-term engagement and control above all other considerations?

It is important not to take companies' statements or actions at face value, particularly when it comes to whether they are for or against advertising. While executives at Perplexity and Anthropic may have principled reasons for keeping AI ad-free, their stances also have a clear economic logic. Both Anthropic and Perplexity rely largely on subscription revenue, and the backlash against OpenAI's adoption of advertising provides an opportunity for competitive differentiation.

As we argue later in this report, the solution to these dilemmas is not to trust the promises of corporations whose guiding principle is profitability. Instead, it is to introduce binding rules of the road to ensure that every business acts transparently, consistently, and fairly, whether they adopt advertising or not.

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26 Hitzig, 'Opinion | OpenAI Is Making the Mistakes Facebook Made. I Quit.'

27 'Claude Is a Space to Think | Anthropic \ Anthropic'.

28 Dooley, 'Anthropic's Claude Commercial Against ChatGPT Ads Delivers Real Results'.

29 *Financial Times*, 'Perplexity Drops Advertising as It Warns It Will Hurt Trust in AI'.

Making AI agents work: the battle over standards and protocols

If general purpose AI agents are to work at scale, they need standardized ways to communicate. The protocols enabling them to interact with tools, databases, service providers, and each other do not yet exist in settled form, but their development is well under way. Decisions made about these standards today will shape the agentic web long into the future, determining what AI agents can do, how they behave, and whose interests they serve.

Big Tech giants are leveraging their market power to ensure their continued dominance in the development of agentic AI. Just as the robots.txt protocol shaped the nature of Web 1.0 and enabled search (and, later, the plundering of online information for AI development), decisions about the next era of protocols will have profound impacts on how digital markets and communications systems operate.

Protocols and standards are the shared technical rules that specify how digital systems communicate and exchange information. By setting defaults for who can access what, and with what controls, they also shape who can profit from that access. Whoever writes these rules will shape the open web, the agentic web, and online markets for years to come.

By establishing standards of communication among AI agents and between AI agents and other systems, protocols create an environment in which agents have a common foundation for discovering, understanding, and collaborating with databases, other software systems, and each other.[30] This reduces reliance on scraping and browser automation, eliminates common points of failure, and makes it far easier for agents to act predictably across multiple services at scale. Protocols thus solve some of agentic AI's previous limitations by replacing expensive, unreliable and non-standardized web scraping with structured, validated, and predictable interactions.

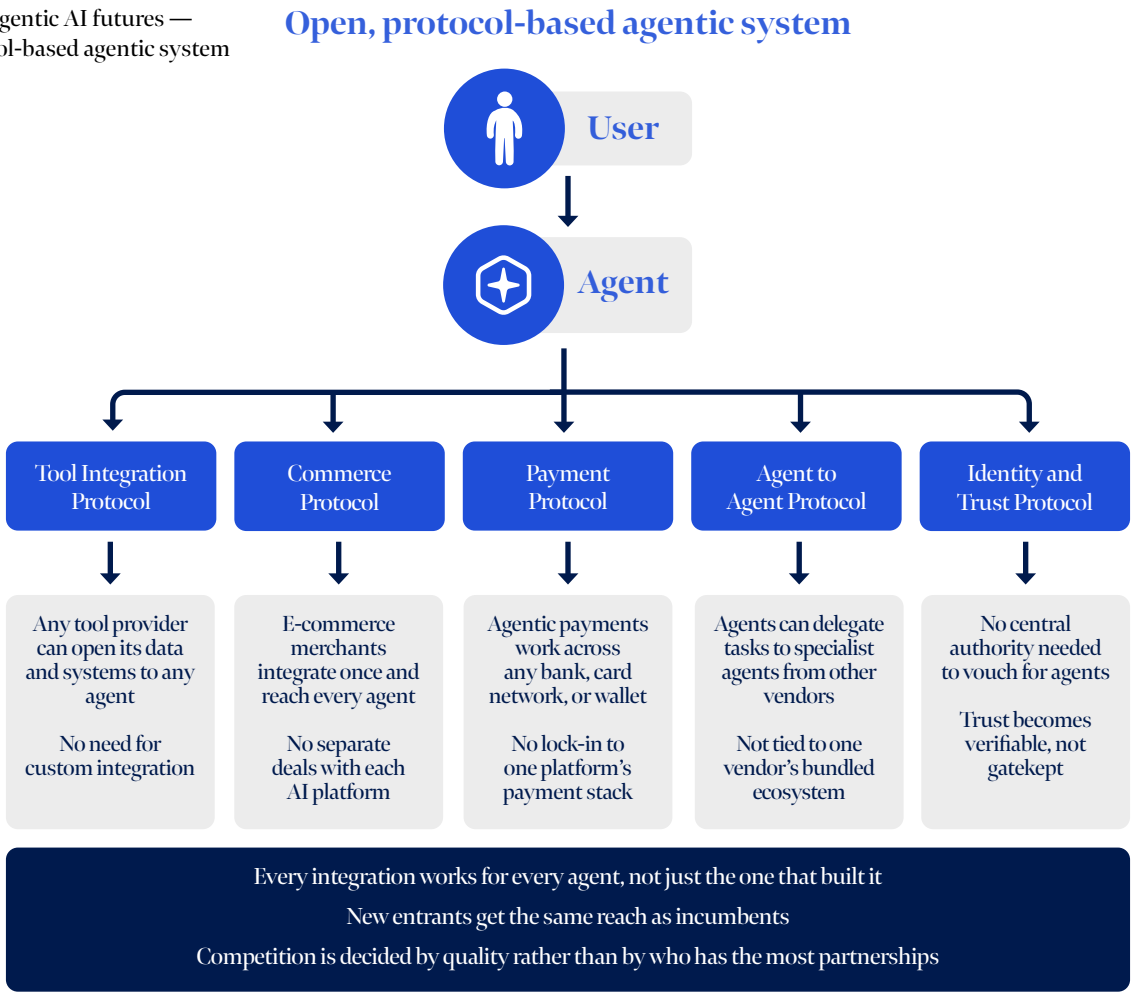
Robots.txt, the lightweight standard used by virtually every website in the world to tell automated crawlers (bots) which parts of a website they may not access, shows how even simple, voluntary commitments can structure the political economy of the web, with profound implications for digital markets and information systems. Even though robots.txt has been one of the basic governance mechanisms of Web 1.0 since the mid-90s, the Internet Engineering Task Force only formally adopted it as a standard in 2022, 28 years after its creation.

Its power came not from law or technical enforcement, but from widespread adoption as search engines, publishers, platforms, and more recently AI developers adopted it as a shared language to communicate access preferences. As a result, a short text file sitting at the root of a website helped determine which information could be indexed, monetized, excluded, or extracted at scale in a machine-readable format. When it comes to agentic AI, the lesson is that standards do not merely solve technical coordination problems: they allocate power by setting defaults, defining who must adapt to whom, and determining whose preferences and interests are built into the architecture of digital markets.

From a competition perspective, influence and control over standards enables powerful firms to shape the underlying logic of the information system in their interests. The history of the digital economy is full of examples of protocols and standards that have entrenched incumbent power, foreclosed alternatives, and entrenched monopolies. This is particularly the case when incumbents have the chance to design these standards. Google's AMP (Accelerated Mobile Pages), an open-source framework for building fast-loading mobile web pages, is especially instructive. Not only did it give Google control over publishers by tying

30 Stryker and Caballar, 'What Are AI Agent Protocols?'

Figure 4a: Agentic AI futures — open, protocol-based agentic system



preferential search placement and access to important features to the adoption of Google's own format,[31] but it also weaved a single company's infrastructure into the fabric of the open web.[32] It is far from the only example.

The central importance of protocols is widely recognized in the AI industry, as OpenAI's Sam Altman showed when he took to X to opine that there "should be a protocol that is equally usable by people and agents."[33] Cloudflare, conversely, has argued for sharpening the distinction between bot and humans by developing new standards and protocols that let content owners verify, meter, and charge for machine access rather than treating it as indistinguishable from a human visit.[34] Its CEO, Matthew Prince,

31 Nguyen, 'Will Publishers Drop AMP When It's No Longer a Requirement for Top Stories?'

32 Montoya and Radsch, 'Beyond Court Remedies in the Google Search Case: A Competition Reform for the Search Ecosystem'.

33 Sam Altman [@sama], 'feels like a good time to seriously rethink how operating systems and user interfaces are designed (also the internet; there should be a protocol that is equally usable by people and agents)'.

34 Radsch, 'AI and the Future of Independent Journalism'.

explained that his "utopian vision is a world where humans get content for free, and robots have to pay a ton for it."[35] Currently, OpenAI and its competitors keep all the money paid by their subscribers, returning none of it to the content providers or businesses that provided the information to the AI assistants in the first place, unless they are among the few publishers fortunate enough to have a deal.

The defaults that get embedded into the architecture of the agentic web will have major implications for fair competition, copyright and contract law, and the overall functioning of digital markets and information systems.[36] Beneath the technical disagreements is a fight over value, accountability, and control. Ignoring the human/agent distinction, for instance, implicitly favors companies that do not want to pay for the content their agents consume.

Early AI protocols are already emerging. In 2024, Anthropic developed what has become an industry standard, the Model Context Protocol (MCP).[37] MCP enables developers to build secure, two-way connections between their AI-powered tools and external data sources, software applications, and other models.[38] Google, meanwhile, has developed the A2A protocol to allow AI agents to communicate with each other, securely exchange information, and coordinate actions on top of enterprise platforms or applications.[39]

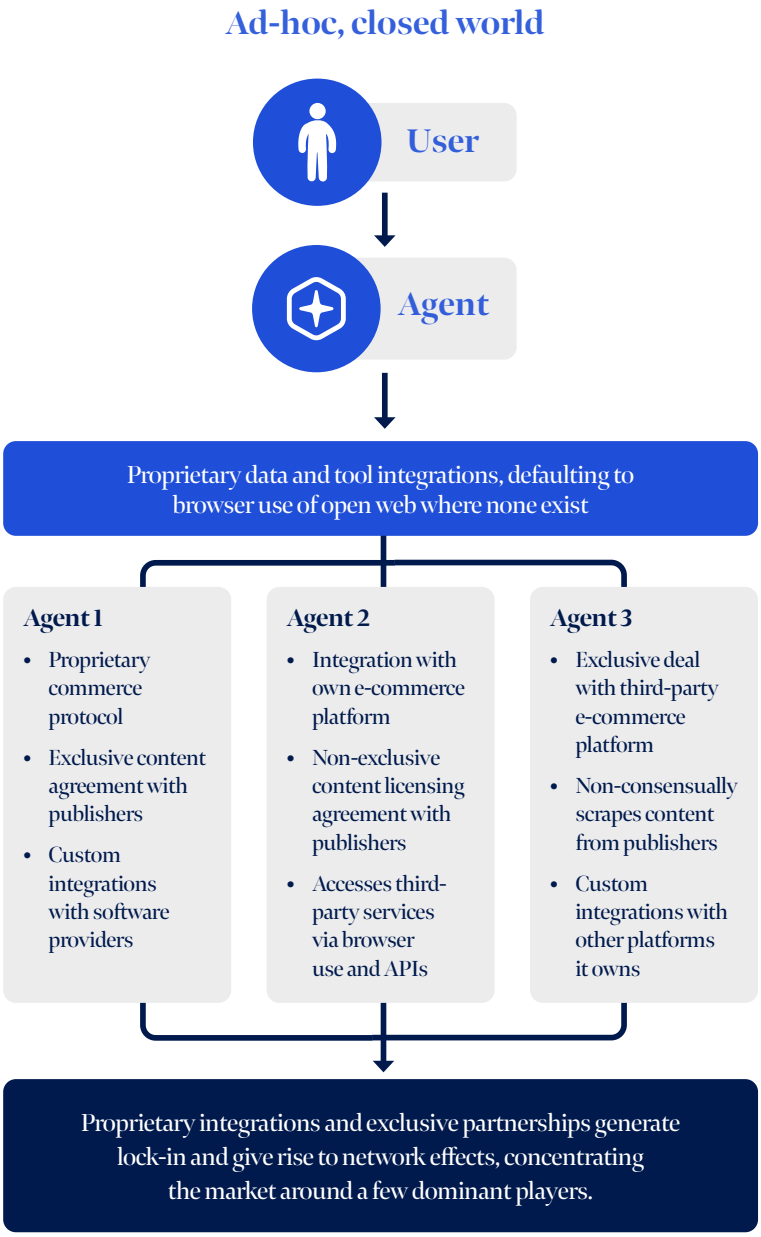


Figure 4b: Closed, proprietary agentic system

35 Perrigo, 'TIME100 AI 2025: Matthew Prince'.

36 Radsch, 'AI Governance as Media Regulation'.

37 'Linux Foundation Announces the Formation of the Agentic AI Foundation (AAIF), Anchored by New Project Contributions Including Model Context Protocol (MCP), Goose and AGENTS.Md'.

38 'What Is the Model Context Protocol (MCP)?'

39 Rao Surapaneni et al., 'Announcing the Agent2Agent Protocol (A2A)'.

Google[40] and OpenAI[41] have also developed competing protocols for the "agentification" of e-commerce. Protocols, in this context, are sets of rules that allow an AI assistant to communicate and interact directly with a merchant's systems (e.g., browsing inventory, checking prices, checking out) without going through a website designed for human navigation. Retailers can thus build a single integration through which AI agents can browse inventory, manage carts, and complete purchases.

Protocol-centric agentic AI is also emerging as a solution for banking and payments,[42] healthcare administration,[43] and government and regulatory services.[44]

While there are many benefits to common standards, we must remain attuned to the way in which they can either enable or inhibit concentration of power and control, as we discuss later in this report.

40 Srinivasan, 'New Tech and Tools for Retailers to Succeed in an Agentic Shopping Era'.

41 OpenAI, 'Buy It in ChatGPT'.

42 Parikh and Surapaneni, 'Announcing Agent Payments Protocol (AP2)'.

43 Ashish Singh et al., 'Introducing HMCP'.

44 Ilves et al., 'The Agentic State'.

Will the market for agentic AI be competitive or concentrated?

Agentic AI is not being developed in a vacuum. It is the product of a specific political economic context: one shaped by the immense power of incumbent tech giants. These corporations leverage this power to both dominate existing technologies and shape the course of future innovation. They do so through their monopolistic control of large parts of the digital economy; their ability to steer innovation trajectories, including in academia and non-profits;[45] their disproportionate sway over policy debates and regulatory enforcement; and their unmatched capacity to attract and deploy capital at scale.[46]

While a gradual shift away from model-centric competition elevates the importance of other competitive factors, many of these factors nonetheless benefit the same set of incumbents, particularly when paired with anti-competitive practices. Distribution advantages, data dominance, network effects, and user lock-in characterize the agentic AI market more than the model market, and are reinforced by existing monopolies elsewhere in the digital economy. These trends point towards a future in which a few monopolists secure the spoils of agentic AI for themselves.

Distribution and integration advantages

Concerns about AI market dominance initially focused on the foundation model and its key inputs: compute and data. While these models remain the core technological innovation around which the entire industry is being built, diminishing returns to model scale have brought other competitive factors to the fore. As models become increasingly interchangeable for many use cases thanks to rapidly improving capabilities in open and closed non-frontier models,[47] the competitive advantages enjoyed by leading-edge foundation model developers are being eroded.

As a result, competitive differentiation is shifting away from raw model performance towards effective application, distribution, and integration. In this landscape, the value of an agentic assistant lies as much, if not more, in the assistant's successful embedding across platforms and services as it does in the underlying model itself.[48] Recognizing this, existing tech monopolies are leveraging their control of platforms used by billions of people and businesses to give preferential treatment and distribution to their own AI agents and assistants. These anti-competitive bundling, tying, and self-preferencing practices are severely distorting nascent competition in the agentic market.

Dominant firms can, and in many cases already do, pre-install or integrate their proprietary agentic assistants as defaults; privilege them in interface placement; restrict API access and limit interoperability for rivals; leverage cross-service data advantages; and raise switching costs through bundling, tying, and other forms of user lock-in.

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45 Rikap, 'Intellectual Monopolies as a New Pattern of Innovation and Technological Regime'.

46 Rikap, *Capitalism, Power and Innovation*; *Financial Times*, 'Big Tech AI Spending Spree Tops $1tn'.

47 Lung, 'Chesky Says OpenAI Tools Not Ready for ChatGPT Tie-Up With Airbnb App'; Emberson, 'Open-Weight Models Lag State-of-the-Art by around 3 Months on Average'.

48 Narayanan, 'Up the Stack'.

They exploit their dominant positions in search (Google), web browsers (Google), mobile operating systems (Google, Apple), PC operating systems (Microsoft, Apple), productivity software (Microsoft, Google), email (Google), messaging (Meta), marketplaces (Amazon), and social media (X, Meta) to project their dominance into AI without fair competition taking place.

Existing examples of this behavior include:

- Meta has been integrating its own AI agent, Muse, directly into WhatsApp and Facebook Messenger and revising WhatsApp's terms of service to prohibit rival AI providers from distributing their services on the platform.[49] Despite an ongoing investigation by the European Commission, Meta still does not give rival providers the same level of integration that its own assistant has, with the AI button and search features all exclusively routing to its own AI.
- Meta giving Muse proprietary integrations with Instagram and Facebook Marketplace that no rivals have.[50]
- Google turning Google Search into a Gemini product, starting with AI Overviews and expanding into AI Mode, allowing users to interact with Gemini directly from the search page.[51] It is planning to eventually replace the traditional search interface with a combination of chatbot and agentic features.[52]
- Google launching "Personal Intelligence," allowing Gemini to connect to Google apps, including Gmail, Google Photos, Search, and YouTube history.[53] Its Gemini Spark assistant promises to manage all aspects of the user's "digital life" from email to shopping to invoicing.[54]
- Microsoft launching "Agent Mode" integrating Copilot into its productivity software suite, including Word, Excel, Teams, and PowerPoint.[55]
- xAI embedding its Grok assistant directly into the X platform as a dedicated tab and letting users summon Grok in any thread.[56] Meta is experimenting with embedding its AI services in Threads in much the same manner.[57]

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49 Autorita' Garante della Concorrenza e del Mercato, 'The Italian Competition Authority launches investigation into Meta over abuse of dominant position'.

50 Rogers, 'Meta's Muse Is Better at Surveilling Than Helping Me'.

51 Reid, 'Google Search with Gemini 3'.

52 Google, 'A New Era for AI Search'.

53 Woodward, 'Gemini Introduces Personal Intelligence'.

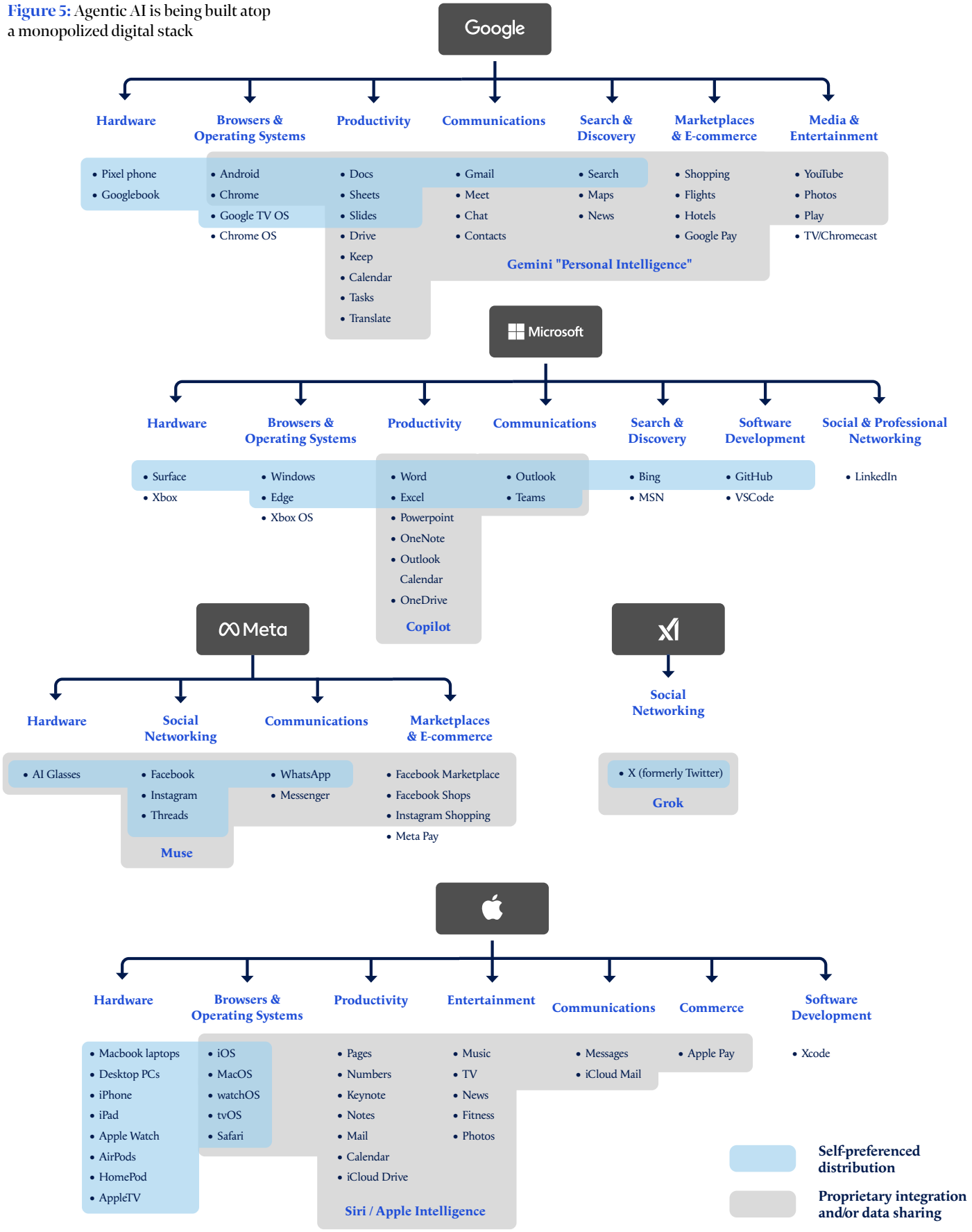
54 Google, 'Gemini Spark — Your 24/7 Personal AI Agent for Productivity'.

55 Chauhan, 'Vibe Working'.

56 Reuters, 'Musk to Integrate xAI with Social Media Platform X'.

57 Malik, 'Threads Tests a Meta AI Integration That Works Similarly to Grok'.

Figure 5: Agentic AI is being built atop a monopolized digital stack



Today's dominant tech firms recognize the power of distribution and integration to achieve usage at scale while limiting the visibility and viability of competitors. Such integration risks entrenching incumbents while stifling competition in the emerging agentic assistant market. This includes competition based on alternative business models, including those more closely aligned with societal needs and democratic values.

Data dominance

One of the things that helped Google build its search and digital advertising monopolies was its ability to gather more data on each individual, and to exploit its power over platforms like Search to put that data to use, including in the service of advertisers.

Initial user engagement was first driven by the outstanding performance of Google's original product, the search engine. User queries generated behavioral data, which in turn improved the effectiveness of targeted ads, thereby attracting advertisers. Advertising revenues — disproportionally high compared to the cost of maintaining an online search engine — allowed Google to reinvest in search as well as to build (Gmail, Drive) or acquire (YouTube) new services. Each service provided new behavioral data streams that further boosted advertising accuracy as well as new platforms across which to sell advertising.

Google's extensive anti-competitive practices, including illegally tying different services together, illegally acquiring competitors like DoubleClick, and paying billions of dollars to become the default search engine on different devices and platforms, fueled a self-perpetuating cycle of reinforcing market power that regulators are still struggling to unwind today.

Exploiting data dominance has since become foundational to many business models across the digital economy, from social media to specialized enterprise tools. There is strong evidence to suggest this dynamic is present and significant in the agentic AI context.[58]

As usage of AI agents and assistants grows, developers acquire richer data about user preferences and whether agents succeed or fail at completing tasks. For this reason, the vast majority of leading AI assistants' terms of use include clauses allowing the use of input data for training.[59] This enables them to refine product performance and personalization, resulting in higher user retention and yet more data. While user interaction data is not especially useful during the initial training of foundation models (pretraining), it is extremely valuable at later stages (fine-tuning), including when using human feedback methods (RLHF) to improve performance.[60] Insights from real-life

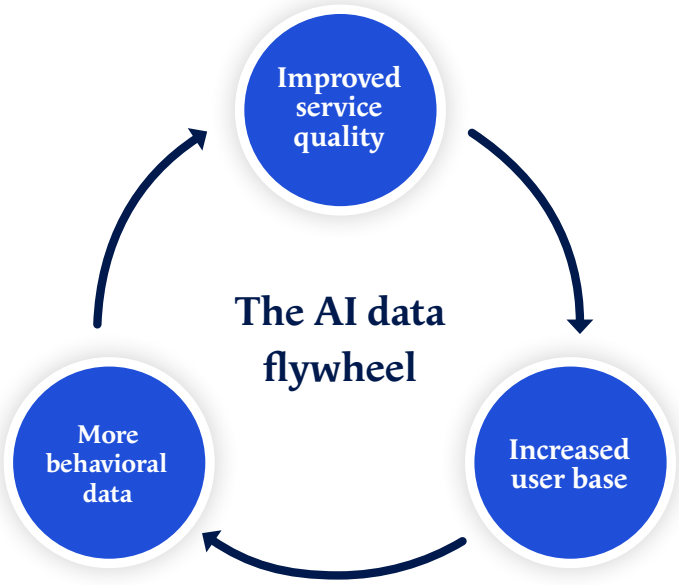


Figure 6: The data flywheel effect

58 Radsch, 'Dismantling AI Data Monopolies Before It's Too Late'.

59 Pandit et al., 'Terms of (Ab)Use'.

60 Dave Bergmann, 'What Is Reinforcement Learning From Human Feedback (RLHF)?'

usage are also crucial for designing engaging interfaces, which in agentic applications could be just as important as model capabilities.[61] This can generate a self-reinforcing feedback loop or flywheel effect where data collected from AI interactions or processes is used to continuously refine AI models, generating better outcomes, higher usage, and more valuable data for continued improvement.[62]

The ability to generate insights from concentrated control of data, and to use these insights to improve products strongly rewards both first movers and dominant corporations that can instantly put their AI agents in front of billions of captive users (often the same actors). Dominant tech firms are also able to use data collected in other markets and for other purposes (such as personal data collected on social media platforms and from search engines) to train and improve their AI models and agents.[63]

Network effects

As this report has shown, technological and economic constraints are steering the development of agentic AI away from the idea of a single general purpose system independently navigating and interacting with the open web. Developers are instead increasingly building systems that operate within — and help shape — a parallel digital layer made up of tools, protocols, proprietary integrations, and purpose-built, agent-friendly web infrastructure.

Whether achieved through proprietary integration or open protocols, this opens the door to a two-sided network effect. These effects arise when a platform that serves two groups becomes more valuable to each group as the other grows. Take the example of a marketplace: the more buyers join a marketplace, the more sellers are incentivized to list on it; then, as more sellers join, even more buyers become attracted, creating a self-perpetuating cycle. This has been a key driver, at least initially, of concentration in many of today's existing tech markets.

For agentic AI, network effects are likely to apply as follows. The more businesses and services are integrated with a particular assistant, the more useful that assistant becomes to users. The more users the assistant has, the more attractive it becomes to businesses: each side pulls the other in. Such a self-reinforcing cycle is hard for rivals to disrupt once established.[64] If AI agents end up becoming two-sided platforms, the likelihood of market concentration increases significantly.

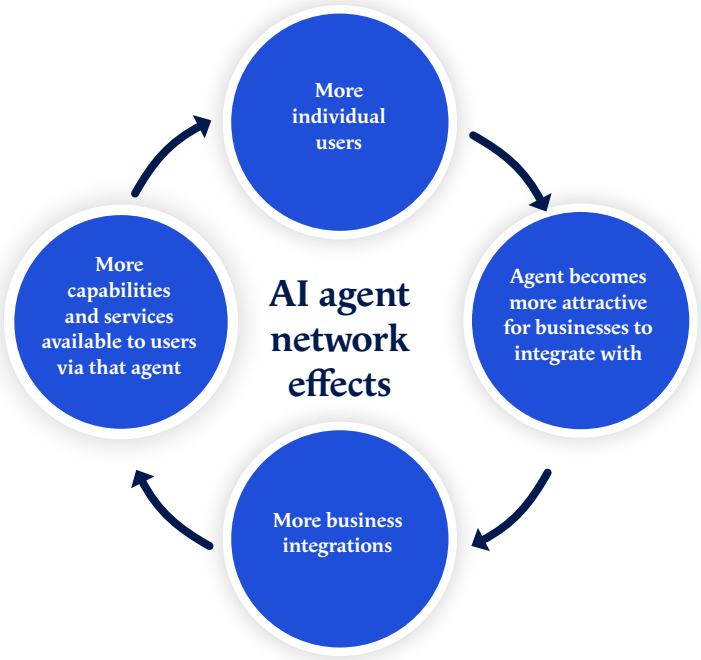


Figure 7: Two-sided network effects in agentic AI

61 Rachitsky, 'The Design Process Is Dead. Here's What's Replacing It. | Jenny Wen (Head of Design at Claude)'.

62 NVIDIA, 'Data Flywheel'.

63 Radsch, 'Dismantling AI Data Monopolies Before It's Too Late'.

64 Rochet and Tirole, 'Platform Competition in Two-Sided Markets'.

These network effects risk creating or entrenching gatekeepers with market power likely exceeding even the control wielded by Apple over its App Store or Amazon over its Marketplace.

This is due to three compounding factors:

1. Agentic assistants can intermediate across many activities and markets simultaneously, rather than within a single marketplace or activity;

2. Agentic assistants shape discovery in ways that are (even) less transparent to users than a search ranking or app store listing (themselves not transparent to begin with);

3. Data generated through agentic interactions may reinforce the assistant's capabilities in ways that further entrench its position, deepening the moat over time.

As with data dominance, the existence of network effects also amplifies the competitive importance of distribution advantages. Firms able to acquire large user bases quickly — notably by bundling AI services with existing products — can quickly reach the scale at which network effects become self-sustaining before rivals can respond or even emerge. Over time, these self-reinforcing dynamics can entrench the position of early leaders and make it more difficult for later entrants to compete, even when they offer superior products.

At the same time, protocols also benefit from network effects: the more agentic assistants adopt a protocol, the more publishers, merchants, and online service providers are likely to adopt it. This is an important source of optimism for a decentralized agentic AI future: if truly open protocols can be made to win out over proprietary integrations, the market can be guided towards a far more hopeful future.

Lock-in

Today's digital monopolies ruthlessly lock customers into using their services. The tighter the lock-in, the more resilient the monopoly. How easy it is to switch between agentic assistants will thus play a central role in determining whether the market tends towards concentration or choice and competition.

There are many potential switching barriers in the agentic assistant market, although at the time of this report's publication, lock-in to specific agentic assistants remains low, at least on the consumer side. For example, Anthropic and OpenAI allow users to export their Claude or ChatGPT data while also making it straightforward for users switching from competing products to import relevant information by prompting their previous assistant to output the preferences, context, and data learned about them. It is critical that such mechanisms remain both technically possible and practically straightforward for users to implement. Rather than relying on companies' discretion, this should be built into legal data portability requirements (for more detail on this, see the Recommendations section of this report).

Nonetheless, there are many ways that consumers could get locked into using specific agentic assistants. These include data lock-in (e.g. conversation histories, personal preferences, and task records), exclusive integrations with third-party services, customized workflows or automations built on a specific agentic platform, and the costs associated with retraining a new system to replicate desired behaviors. As assistants become more deeply embedded in users' lives and significantly more personalized, the potential for lock-in will only increase.

On the business side, the incentives for agentic developers to create lock-in are obvious: each third-party service integrated with the platform expands the AI assistant's capabilities. Despite these incentives, some current trends are encouraging, as large parts of the agentic web are developing around open-source protocols (notably MCP). These protocols lower integration and switching costs, as connecting a third party's booking engine, inventory database, or customer service tool becomes equally straightforward and possible for all assistants.

That said, the mere existence of protocols doesn't make a market immune to lock-in. Some protocols

are both open and proprietary: their specifications are publicly available but controlled by one company. This is for instance the case for the Agentic Commerce Protocol: open, but developed and controlled by OpenAI and Stripe. Others, like Google's Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP), have clearly been designed with their creators' wider business portfolios — such as Google's advertising monopoly — in mind.

While UCP is technically open-source, using it effectively requires merchants to sign up to Google's advertising monopoly. Merely setting up UCP will not automatically make a merchant's products appear in people's agentic AI shopping carts. If a merchant wants to have their products available in Google's AI services (Gemini and AI Mode), they will only be able to do so if they have an active Google Merchant Center account and subscribe to Google Pay.[65] Once signed up, merchants are then invited to use Google's tools to "optimize [their] presence in the conversational commerce era." What is presented on paper as an open-source solution is in fact an attempt to lock in merchants — and their advertising — as part of Google's latest effort to entrench its advertising monopoly.

Regulators must push back against these pseudo-open protocols and promote truly universal, public standards that minimize switching costs.

Even if the agentic web ends up being built around open protocols, businesses may still face significant costs moving between or across agentic platforms. Integrating with different platforms may come with non-technical requirements: cybersecurity or quality certifications, data sharing and data quality demands, or financial conditions on pricing and revenue sharing.

Then there are the reputational benefits, customer relationships, and distribution advantages built up by a particular agentic platform, much like a retailer selling through Amazon risks losing visibility by moving elsewhere or refusing to abide by the platform's rules and protocols, no matter how unfair. Trade-offs in such commercial decisions are unavoidable. But agentic platforms cannot be allowed to impose lock-in through unfair and anti-competitive practices.

The role of advertising in entrenching market power

The huge costs of training and operating AI agents are fueling a race to find a viable business model.[66]

Historically, Big Tech firms and many other software companies have generated revenue from (1) enterprise software contracts (2) consumer software subscriptions and (3) advertising sales in consumer services that are typically free to use. For AI assistants not sold as enterprise solutions or subscriptions, advertising is an inevitable monetization strategy. Agentic assistants offer an attractive advertising platform: they are interactive and deeply personalized thanks to data collected from multi-step interactions, as well as directly drive user decisions.

OpenAI started rolling out advertising in the United States and the UK in 2026 for its free and lowest-tiered subscriptions, having previously claimed it would never do so.[67] It has since launched a self-service platform for advertisers[68] and boldly forecast advertising revenues of $100 billion by 2030.[69] Meta, at its core an advertising company, is betting heavily on AI as a tool for automating the traditional online

65 Google, 'Google Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP) Guide | Google for Developers'.

66 Open Markets Institute, 'Report - No Bailouts for Big Tech Billionaires'.

67 Babu and Kachwala, 'OpenAI to Test Ads in ChatGPT in Bid to Boost Revenue'; OpenAI, 'Testing Ads in ChatGPT'.

68 OpenAI, 'New Ways to Buy ChatGPT Ads'.

69 Reuters, 'OpenAI Projects $2.5 Billion in Ad Revenue This Year, $100 Billion by 2030, Axios Reports'.

advertising workflow.[70] Though it does not yet use its AI assistant as an ad delivery channel, it is likely to do so. Corporations able to combine AI with existing monopolistic control over online advertising (Google and Meta) are particularly well placed in this regard.[71]

AI assistants drive consumer decisions both directly and indirectly in at least two ways. The first is through direct influence: when an agent is tasked with shopping (through price comparison, managing wish lists, or making purchases on the user's behalf), it can steer users toward specific products and services. Secondly and more subtly, agents can also more indirectly shape long-term preferences and behaviors by giving suggestions in casual interactions involving planning, researching, and organizing.

Capitalizing on the commercial potential of this influence for advertising purposes requires deep personalization, which in turn incentivizes the collection and analysis of more and more user data. The same forces that fueled concentration in traditional online advertising — that is, the close connection between the accuracy and effectiveness of targeted ads and the quantity and quality of data they are based on — are therefore set to apply in the AI context, with similar impacts.

Investments, partnerships, and acquisitions

At a first glance, the AI industry may appear diverse. Half-century-old Microsoft and dot-com era stalwarts Google and Meta compete with OpenAI, a relatively unknown research lab until 2022, and Anthropic, an OpenAI offshoot founded five years ago. All of these AI players offer some type of agentic assistant, with differing functionalities and prices. This apparent variety however obscures the reality concealed by a web of commercial and technical dependencies and conflicts of interest.

The first layer of this web is investment and ownership. Microsoft currently holds a 27% stake in OpenAI,[72] and, under a revenue-sharing clause, receives 20% of OpenAI's revenues.[73] Anthropic, for its part, has received $13 billion and $10 billion investments from Amazon and Google respectively,[74] giving each of them an approximate 15% ownership stake.[75] Nvidia, to date the biggest beneficiary of the AI boom, enthusiastically reinvests its profits in the burgeoning market. It holds stakes in OpenAI,[76] xAI,[77] Reflection AI,[78] and Europe-based Mistral,[79] as well as several data center operators, known as "neoclouds," that rent its chips to AI companies.[80] Most recently, it

70 Reuters, 'Meta Aims to Fully Automate Advertising with AI by 2026, WSJ Reports'.

71 Google, 'A New Generation of Ads for the AI Era of Search'.

72 Ford and Ghaffary, 'Microsoft to Get 27% of OpenAI, Access to AI Models Until 2032 - Bloomberg'.

73 Capoot, 'OpenAI Shakes up Partnership with Microsoft, Capping Revenue Share Payments'.

74 Amazon, 'Amazon and Anthropic Expand Strategic Collaboration'.

75 Bellan, 'Google to Invest up to $40B in Anthropic in Cash and Compute'.

76 Capoot, 'Nvidia Plans to Invest up to $100 Billion in OpenAI as Part of Data Center Buildout'.

77 Kolodny, 'Elon Musk's xAI Raises $20 Billion from Investors Including Nvidia, Cisco, Fidelity'.

78 Hammond et al., 'Nvidia in Talks to Acquire US "Open" Model Start-up Reflection AI'.

79 Iordache, 'AI Firm Mistral Valued at $14 Billion as Chip Giant ASML Takes Major Stake'.

80 Iyer, 'Nvidia Invests $2B to Help Debt-Ridden CoreWeave Add 5GW of AI Compute'; Reuters, 'Nvidia to Invest $2 Billion in Neocloud Nebius amid AI Data Center Push'.

announced plans to acquire Hugging Face, the leading hub for open-source AI models, extending its reach from chips and capital into how AI models are distributed.[81]

These investments by Big Tech are not simply venture capital-style bets on the startups' future success: they finance future demand for their own services while distorting competitive incentives between investors and investees. Microsoft previously held exclusive rights to the hosting and distribution of OpenAI products on its Azure cloud and remains a "preferred partner." In return for Amazon's investment, Anthropic committed to spending $100 billion on Amazon Web Services over the coming decade. Similarly, Nvidia's investments come with purchase commitment clauses. These circular deals, while not technically illegal, trap liquidity, concentrate risk, and sustain what remains a speculative investment boom.[82]

Big Tech firms are also using "acquihires" to capture the talent of potential competitors without triggering antitrust scrutiny. This includes Google hiring Windsurf's entire leadership team,[83] Meta acquiring Scale AI's,[84] and Microsoft absorbing Inflection AI.[85] These are just a few examples of the way that tech giants use their unmatched financial resources to concentrate AI talent in their hands, while hobbling or co-opting smaller challengers, many of them in the field of agentic AI.

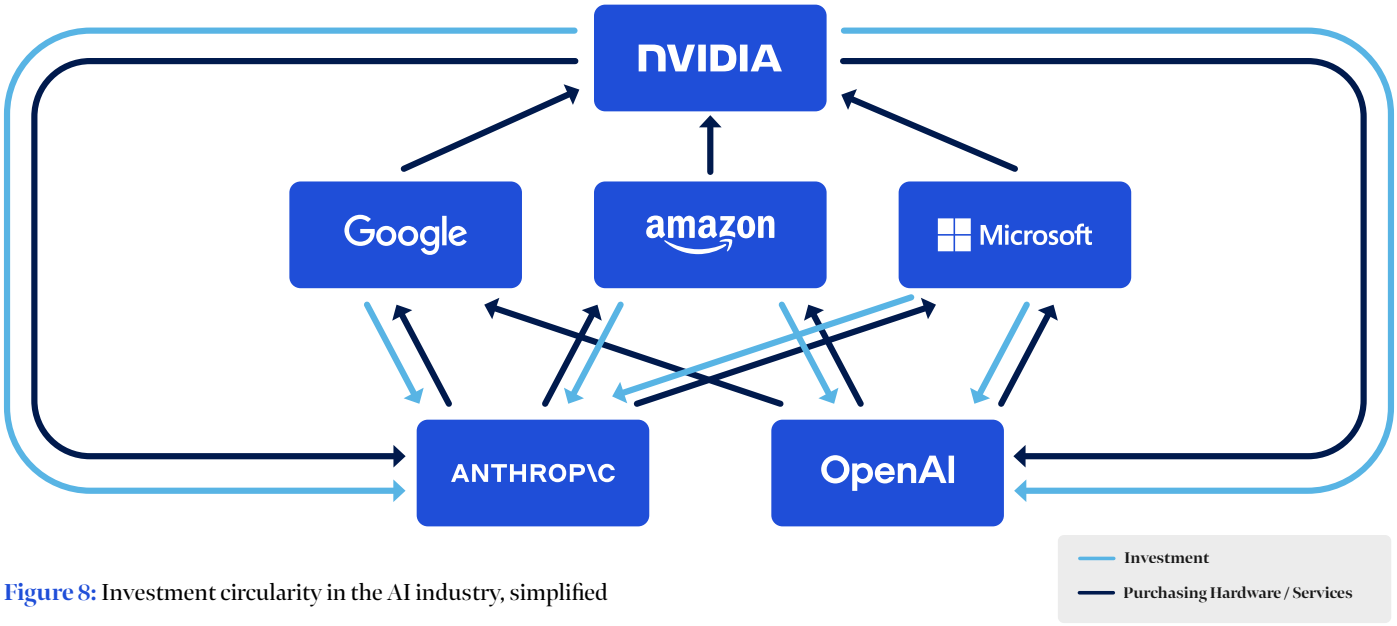


Figure 8: Investment circularity in the AI industry, simplified

81 Acton, 'Nvidia to Buy Open-Source AI Platform Hugging Face for $13bn'.

82 Sam et al., 'A Guide to the Circular Deals Underpinning the AI Boom'.

83 Srinivasaragavan, 'Google Hires Windsurf Heads in $2.4bn Licensing Deal'.

84 Heath, 'Meta Is Paying $14 Billion to Catch up in the AI Race'.

85 Heath, 'Microsoft Reuses Its OpenAI Playbook'.

How monopoly control of AI agents threatens our future

Concentrated control of AI systems, and agentic assistants in particular, pose a wide range of risks to our economies and democracies.

A world in which one or a handful of private actors mediate and curate the world's access to information, set the terms for online commerce and advertising, and have unparalleled access to vast quantities of personal data, is a world of widespread manipulation, extortion, and top-down control.[86]

To a large extent, this is the world we already live in. One in which Google dominates online search while Meta, TikTok, and X control social networks, imposing ubiquitous surveillance and algorithmic manipulation as the dominant logic of the information system. One in which Apple and Google carve up app stores while Amazon owns the infrastructural plumbing of e-commerce, letting these behemoths unilaterally set commercial terms for the digital economy. And a world where Amazon, Apple, Google, and Microsoft control computing itself through their operating systems, devices, and cloud infrastructure. However, while each of these monopolists control one or several fiefdoms of the digital economy, AI agents raise the prospect of this power being brought together under a single empire.

> **This is about power. It is about who controls the gateways through which human intention must pass to become action in the world. Before AI, when you asked Google a question, you still had to click, compare, evaluate, decide. When you booked a flight through Expedia, you still saw the alternatives. When you scrolled Amazon, you retained the impression, at least, of browsing and choosing. The agentic assistant collapses all of this. It does not present options so much as it selects them, though its criteria are unknown and potentially unknowable. It does not surface information so much as filters, reinterprets, and frames it. The corporations that control the agent control, in a very real sense, the texture of a user's reality: their commercial decisions, their information environment, and their sense of what is possible and what is not.**[87]

The rest of this report concretely demonstrates the dangers that follow from allowing concentrated agentic control to develop: centralized epistemic power, economic power, and surveillance power. It outlines the risks this poses to society, including the suppression and distortion of innovation, widespread surveillance, the weakening of societal resilience, and centralized corporate control over information flows, including those critical to the functioning of democracy.

Democratic and societal risks

Without clear restrictions on how agentic AI systems can influence or manipulate people, other digital systems, or the physical world, we are exposing society and democracy to serious risks. Agentic AI is likely to amplify many of the harms perpetrated by social media platforms and profit-driven algorithmic curation while introducing new and potentially even more dangerous threats.

86 Radsch, 'The Battle for Cognitive Liberty in the Age of Corporate AI'.

87 ibid

As AI agents and assistants increasingly intermediate people's access to information, the actors controlling these technologies will determine how political views are formed and expressed. Their concentrated power risks distorting information flows, introducing dangerous points of failure, and even undermining state capacity and sovereignty itself.

Centralized control and influence over information flows

People increasingly rely on AI agents and assistants to access news and information, including on political issues,[88] and to make decisions based on that information. Whoever controls these tools thus shapes what information people see and how it is presented to them, creating opportunities for both direct and indirect influence.

This holds even where a provider seeks to build a neutral assistant. Even without top-down interference, the design of an AI system inevitably shapes the information it surfaces and how this information is presented. Biases in training data and the design decisions of model developers can systematically skew the perspectives that users are exposed to in ways that are difficult to detect.[89] Models necessarily reflect the moral and political beliefs of their designers, data labelers, and the people involved in reinforcement learning from human feedback (RLHF) training processes.[90] Market concentration makes these risks even more acute: when a small number of providers control the market, their biases and editorial choices affect a vast number of users, with little competitive pressure to correct course.

AI assistants can also be designed to avoid certain topics. Though some of this is aimed at restricting illegal speech, hate speech, or profanity, AI outputs also reflect the ideological and political views of their developers. This has been documented in Chinese AI models as well as American and European models, though with different focuses.[91]

Just as concerningly, influence over assistant outputs can be exploited directly and intentionally through editorial intervention by platform owners.[92] Research by the UK's AI Security Institute (AISI) found that LLMs can be made more politically persuasive via post-training and prompting methods.[93] It also showed that a systematic correlation exists between increased persuasiveness and decreased factual accuracy, demonstrating the potential for political manipulation. This is not only a problem for citizens but also for politicians, who increasingly use AI to inform themselves and draft speeches and policies.[94]

The threat of political manipulation of AI outputs is not hypothetical. xAI's Grok, owned by Elon Musk, briefly censored "unflattering mentions" of Trump and

88 Luettgau et al., 'Conversational AI Increases Political Knowledge as Effectively as Self-Directed Internet Search'; Simon et al., 'Generative AI and News Report 2025'.

89 Becchetti and Solferino, 'Political Biases in ChatGPT'.

90 Humphreys, 'AI's Epistemic Harm'.

91 SpeechMap.AI, 'Lab Leaderboard'.

92 Radsch and von Thun, 'Defending Europe's Digital Sovereignty'.

93 Hackenburg et al., 'The Levers of Political Persuasion with Conversational Artificial Intelligence'.

94 Loi and Marsh, 'Could AI Chatbots Influence a Government's Decisions?'; James, 'Labour MPs Accused of Using ChatGPT to Write Speeches'.

Musk in early 2025.[95] Later that year, Grok was fine-tuned or prompted to be more aligned with Musk's personal political stances. This resulted in the assistant calling itself "MechaHitler," publishing unsolicited rants about "white genocide" in South Africa, and recommending Hitler as the person to deal with "anti-white hate".[96] This clumsy attempt at manipulation provoked ridicule, but the possibility of more subtle versions of the same behavior is a serious concern.[97]

Market concentration in AI thus facilitates political censorship and discourse manipulation, including by state actors. The Trump administration's executive orders directing AI companies to remove diversity-related considerations from model outputs[98] illustrate how concentrated technological architecture can become a political lever available to whoever controls or can pressure large corporations. China, for instance, has imposed guidelines on its AI developers, resulting in domestic AI models that systematically refuse to engage with politically sensitive subjects including Tiananmen Square, Taiwan, and criticism of the Communist Party.[99]

Concentration of power among a handful of AI agents and assistants thus poses three compounding threats to our information ecosystems, and therefore to democracy itself. The fewer the actors who develop and distribute these systems, the greater the risks:

1. The embedded assumptions and editorial choices of AI agents, whether intentional or unintentional, shape the presentation of information and narrow the range of perspectives users encounter, undermining the pluralism on which democratic discourse depends;

2. Private actors with anti-democratic motives can exercise editorial control over vast swathes of the public sphere all around the world, effectively imprinting their political and moral preferences on billions of people without accountability or transparency;

3. States are able to leverage these centralized systems for propaganda, censorship, or the manipulation of political outcomes at scale.

The effect in each case is similar: the information ecosystem of potentially billions of users is shaped not by users but by the values and material interests of whoever controls the agent and its underlying model, whether a state, a corporation, or a combination of both.

Importantly, AI systems' agentic nature compounds these risks. Not only will bias or censorship affect the information users receive in response to questions, but as agentic capabilities are used to draft text for documents, emails, and speeches, these systems will increasingly speak for us as well.

Rinse and Repeat: Agentic AI and the Digital Information Ecosystem

Search engines and social media platforms have long been the gatekeepers of online information, with Google and Meta in particular steering global internet traffic and online social interaction.[100] Profit-driven search and

95 Wiggers, 'Grok 3 Appears to Have Briefly Censored Unflattering Mentions of Trump and Musk'.

96 Hagen, 'Elon Musk's AI Chatbot, Grok, Started Calling Itself "MechaHitler"'; Conger, 'Employee's Change Caused xAI's Chatbot to Veer Into South African Politics'.

97 Radsch, 'The Battle for Cognitive Liberty in the Age of Corporate AI'.

98 Executive Order 14319: Preventing Woke AI in the Federal Government.

99 Pan and Xu, 'Political Censorship in Large Language Models Originating from China'.

100 The Cloudflare Blog, 'ChatGPT-s Rivals, Kwai-s Quiet Rise- the Top Internet Services of 2025'.

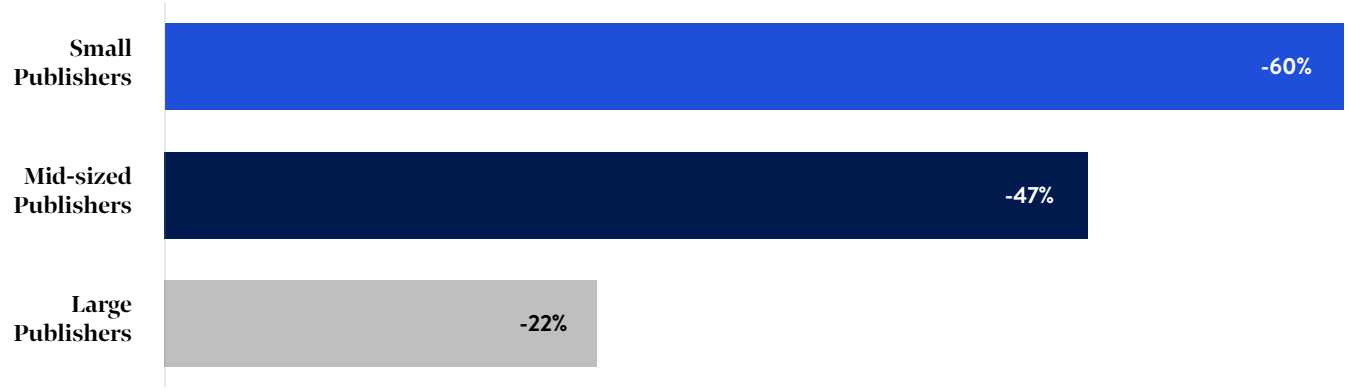


Figure 9: Decline in publisher referrals from traditional search engines, by size (2023-2025)

Source: Chartbeat data, as reported by Axios (March 17, 2026). Analysis by Center for Journalism & Liberty / Open Markets Institute. Created with the assistance of Claude AI (Anthropic).

social media recommendation algorithms today largely determine people's exposure to content and which journalistic products and perspectives have a chance at winning their attention. This has shaped the editorial strategies and business models of media, journalism, and the creative industries, which are increasingly cut off from direct contact with their audiences.[101] AI assistants and agents are taking this process one step further. They scrape sources without referrals or citations, summarize and generate content without oversight or verification, and provide users with synthesized content that may or may not be accurate or real.

AI is thus further undermining the economic foundation of independent media and journalism. Most outlets are seeing dramatic drops in referral traffic, with several reporting drops in advertising income exceeding 40% and conservative estimates putting industrywide losses at $2 billion annually from AI-powered "zero-click" search.[102] Users who look up information with AI hardly ever navigate to the sources: AI applications account for less than 1% of publisher traffic,[103] with click-through rates far below classic search. Google still delivers roughly 85% of external referral traffic, making its enthusiastic implementation of AI mode an existential threat for many publishers.[104] At the same time, Google AI Search Mode and other AI applications generate their answers using content from the very websites they cut off from their audiences, often without attribution or compensation.

In an attempt to balance the relations between publishers and AI companies, the European Commission has opened a formal investigation into whether Google is using publisher content to power AI services without appropriate consent or compensation,[105] and the UK now requires Google to provide publishers with an opt-

101 Radsch, *Platformization and Media Capture*.

102 Radsch and Montoya, 'Same Gatekeepers, New Tollbooths: Mapping the AI Content Licensing Market'.

103 Hazard Owen, 'AI Sources like ChatGPT Account for Less than 1% of Publishers' Pageviews, Chartbeat Says'.

104 Suleyman, 'Search Engine Market Share Q3 2026'.

105 Allyn, 'Online News Publishers Face "extinction-Level Event" from Google's AI-Powered Search'; European Commission, 'Commission Opens Investigation into Possible Anticompetitive Conduct by Google'.

out option for its AI products and prohibits retaliation for doing so.[106] Such rebalancing is sorely needed as smaller publishers experience even bigger losses in referral traffic[107] — a dynamic that will exacerbate the consolidation of the information landscape.

Journalistic outlets are just one part of the online information landscape. Community-driven encyclopedias like Wikipedia, user forums like Reddit, and personal blogs or websites hosted individually or on platforms like Substack or WordPress, all rely on internet search and social media for visibility. Wikipedia attributes an 8% year-on-year decline in site traffic to answers retrieved by AI, while Reddit, whose business model rests on advertising, has seen its stock price fall as Google AI Overviews reduces user visits.[108] If AI results in an overall reduction in the amount of information available online, then this would not only affect publishers and citizens, but also AI itself, which ultimately relies on access to diverse and high-quality information to provide useful outputs to users.

Dominant AI firms already hold significant power over licensing terms, compensation, visibility, and content presentation, and can discriminate or retaliate against those who oppose them with impunity.[109] Publishers and websites that don't comply risk disappearing entirely from agents' output. As journalistic content is an essential input for AI services, AI companies are stepping in to subsidize news reporting through bespoke licensing deals, direct production, and "partnerships"[110] that further entrench dependency while fending off potential regulation.[111] Similarly, websites that host user-generated content will need to optimize interactions for analysis by agents, limiting room for genuine community engagement.

In other words, tech giants that have relentlessly extracted rents through their advertising monopolies and underpriced both journalistic and user-generated content are now poised to drive the news market towards producing material for agents rather than people.[112] This risks incentivizing homogenous, low-risk, low-cost reporting, and agent-optimized material rather than independent, high-quality information, and complex investigative reporting.

Amplified corporate surveillance

We already inhabit a world in which seemingly every one of our on- and offline actions is surveilled by private corporations that either use that information to manipulate us directly, or sell it to the highest bidder for profit — whether that is an advertiser or a state actor.[113] Agentic AI, by collecting and combining an unprecedented depth and breadth of personal data, risks taking these practices to new extremes.

As envisioned by their makers, and without robust privacy safeguards, AI assistants will be able to access all the data held on a person's device, including any accounts and software systems they are connected to. That means

106 Radsch, 'UK Regulator Staunches Google's AI Content Grab'.

107 Fischer, 'Exclusive: Small Publishers Hit Hardest by Search Traffic Declines'.

108 Miller, 'New User Trends on Wikipedia'; *Dallas Express*, 'Is Google's AI Killing Reddit Traffic?'

109 Radsch and Montoya, 'Same Gatekeepers, New Tollbooths: Mapping the AI Content Licensing Market'.

110 OpenAI Global Affairs, 'A Different Path on Local News'; 'OpenAI Expands Initiatives to Support Journalism from Classrooms to Newsrooms'; Fu, 'An AI Company Set out to Fix News Deserts. Instead, It Copied Local Journalists' Work'.

111 Papaevangelou, 'Funding Intermediaries'.

112 Radsch, 'Expert Brief - A Framework for Establishing Journalism's Value in Artificial Intelligence Systems'.

113 Joffe-Block, 'Your Data Is Everywhere. The Government Is Buying It without a Warrant'.

email and text messages, bank and investment accounts, browsing data and purchase histories, location data, sensitive documents including health records, and much more.[114] In addition to accessing existing data, the conversational, anthropomorphic, and potentially addictive nature of today's leading consumer-facing AI products is giving them unparalleled insights into people's intimate beliefs, secrets, aspirations, and fears.

While consensual access to and use of that data is not inherently problematic, its mere existence creates extraordinary opportunities — and therefore temptations — for exploitation and manipulation. Private and state actors that wish to manipulate people into buying certain products, believing certain things, or acting in certain ways, are willing to pay a high price for information enabling them to do so. Versions of this already happen: Google was caught selling personal data that allowed data brokers to explicitly categorize users as bankrupt, chronically ill, or national security decision makers.[115] Whether intentionally or not, agentic AI brings this information together under a single umbrella.

At a bare minimum, users should be able to decide what data agentic AI systems access and infer on their devices and in their accounts. But this alone will be insufficient. Many AI-use cases will require access to sensitive data, which people may still agree to, but experience has shown the limits of consent requirements in protecting people's privacy, due to "consent fatigue" and successful efforts by companies to bury privacy settings or frame them in misleading ways, among other reasons.

Without limits — including legal, regulatory and competitive limits — on the ways in which this data can be collected and used, firms will have strong incentives to exploit it in ways that are incompatible with, and often actively harmful to, users' interests. Though surveillance of this type is not limited to concentrated markets, a single AI monopolist or small set of powerful firms would have the scale and capabilities to extensively surveil millions or billions at once, the entrenched market power to keep them from leaving, and the political power to resist regulation.

State capture and threats to sovereignty

Market concentration in AI risks creating multiple avenues for state capture and control, from governments being locked into one or a small number of monopolistic private providers, to direct political influence by dominant corporations over governments. Where countries are dependent on dominant corporations from other jurisdictions, these threats pose a direct challenge to their sovereignty.

In the United States, Elon Musk was appointed by President Trump in early 2025 to briefly head the Department for Government Efficiency (DOGE). Musk used this as an opportunity to accelerate xAI's integration into federal agencies, gaining access to unprecedented troves of confidential data. This created a situation in which the analytical infrastructure of the United States' government became operationally dependent on an AI model owned by the richest man in the world with financial interests across industries that same government regulates.[116] Since then, several other leading AI companies have increased their presence at the heart of the U.S. state. They include including Google, which has signed a classified deal with the Pentagon;[117] OpenAI, which has deals with the U.S. Department of War and has offered its services below cost to induce government adoption of

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114 Autoriteit Persoonsgegevens, *AP Warns of Major Security Risks with AI Agents like OpenClaw*.

115 Cameron and Mehrotra, 'Google Ad-Tech Users Can Target National Security "Decision Makers" and People With Chronic Diseases'.

116 Musk also controls a significant portion of low earth orbit satellites and outer space travel and flight on which the US government relies: Taylor et al., 'Musk's DOGE Expanding His Grok AI in US Government, Raising Conflict Concerns'.

117 Woo, 'Google Signs Classified AI Deal With Pentagon Amid Employee Opposition'.

its services;[118] and Anthropic, which is now feuding with the Trump administration over whether its AI should be used in autonomous weapons and mass surveillance.[119]

The underlying, structural concern here is what researchers have termed "algocracy": the progressive substitution of algorithmic for democratic authority.[120] This is not only about autonomous AI directly replacing human decision-making. It is also about how efficiency pressures, supplier dependency, and technical complexity gradually transfer consequential decisions about eligibility, resource allocation, regulatory review, legislative drafting, and the like from human institutions to opaque algorithmic systems. It is about accountable human-centered processes being replaced by systems whose reasoning cannot be examined, contested, or overridden without access to data and specialized technical knowledge that most citizens, legislators, and regulators do not possess.

While the formal architecture of democracy may remain intact, its substance risks being migrated to a layer that democratic institutions and processes cannot effectively scrutinize or hold accountable. Substituting algorithmic for human authority within the institutions of government itself thus risks further consolidating the power that the corporate owners of these systems already have over democratic processes. What's more, governments that become largely or wholly dependent on private AI systems for their basic functioning have less leverage over the corporate owners of these systems, whether it's about getting a better deal for taxpayers or regulating their technology in the public interest.

For countries that lack domestic companies developing competitive AI models and applications, these forms of state capture and dependency are a direct threat to national sovereignty. In a market dominated by AI firms from two countries — the United States and China — and in a time of growing geopolitical tensions, the rest of the world is on a path towards economic and technological dependence on infrastructure controlled by geopolitical superpowers engaged in a battle for global supremacy. Governments that build essential services and infrastructure on foreign-owned AI not only expose themselves to external interference and coercion, but also undermine their own ability to regulate these systems in the interests of their citizens. While governments can reduce these risks by limiting, or at least diversifying, internal usage of foreign systems for public services, their sovereignty is still at risk if the economy and society at large remain dependent.

As a striking illustration of these risks, the U.S. government recently limited the release of Anthropic's Fable 5 model to U.S. citizens, albeit temporarily (this time at least). The merging of U.S. state and private AI interests is becoming increasingly significant, as OpenAI proposes that the government receive a 5% ownership stake in leading AI companies.

Once again, the challenge is proportional to the degree of concentration in the AI market. The fewer the players in the market, the greater the ease with which they can convert their economic power into political advantage.

Atomization and homogenization of the public

As AI assistants increasingly intermediate or replace human interactions, individuals may become more socially isolated. At the same time, there is a real risk that the homogeneity of AI outputs and actions suppresses the diversity of tastes, preferences, and perspectives that together make up a pluralistic society. Both of these eventualities bring challenges to

118 Bellan, 'OpenAI Is Practically Giving ChatGPT to the Government for Free'; U.S. Department of War, 'Department of War Launches OpenAI's ChatGPT Mil on GenAI.Mil'.

119 Hagey et al., 'Anthropic-Pentagon Clash Over Limits on AI Puts $200 Million Contract at Risk'.

120 Lorenz et al., 'The Algocracy as a New Ideal Type for Government Organizations'.

our prosperity and democracy. Both are significantly more likely in a concentrated agentic AI market.

Atomization

First, atomization. This is not a new phenomenon. Émile Durkheim was thinking about it amidst the social and political upheaval brought about by the Industrial Revolution.[121] Writing in the aftermath of mid-century fascism and the Second World War, Hannah Arendt showed how disconnection from the institutions, associations, and shared realities that make collective political life possible can produce profound forms of social and political isolation, to the detriment of democracy.[122]

While atomization predates digital technology, the ways in which these technologies are designed, deployed, and governed can accelerate or intensify it. Communal leisure,[123] a shared information environment,[124] and opportunities for face-to-face social interaction with people across social boundaries[125] are already being weakened and displaced by more individualized forms of technology-driven consumption and interaction, threatening the shared bonds necessary for effective democracy.

A key question is how choices made in the design of AI systems alter social behavior and reshape people's environments. Though these societal impacts are often unintentional effects of these choices, the outcomes, in some cases harmful, are real. This matters particularly where only a few actors make decisions about AI: if a small number of firms control the systems through which people access information, entertainment, services, and increasingly social interaction, their vision of digital life becomes difficult for people to opt out of.

With this in mind, the vision of agentic AI pursued by today's dominant corporations AI is deeply problematic. Their AI assistants are designed to maximize convenience, permanent engagement and revenue maximization by mediating an ever-greater set of everyday interactions and functions. In doing so, they seek to encourage people to substitute AI for activities previously undertaken with other people or through shared social institutions.

For democracy and social cohesion, this raises serious risks. A public sphere depends not only on individuals having formal freedom of choice, but on the continued availability of social spaces, institutions, and interactions through which people encounter one another and perspectives different to their own. If AI comes to mediate and personalize not only what people see and consume, but also how they communicate, learn, make decisions, purchase goods and services, and organize their lives, the values and priorities of the firms designing AI will shape the conditions under which people interact with one another at enormous scale.

Homogenization

The growing influence of algorithms over different facets of our lives also poses risks of homogenization or algorithmic "monoculture." This is the idea that the widespread use of the same or closely related algorithms produces increasingly homogeneous choices, preferences, and — with agentic AI — actions.[126] The risk is particularly significant where a small number

121 Durkheim, *De la division du travail social*.

122 Arendt, *The Origins of Totalitarianism*.

123 Olken, 'Do Television and Radio Destroy Social Capital?'

124 Ross Arguedas et al., *Echo Chambers, Filter Bubbles, and Polarisation*.

125 Putnam, *Bowling Alone*.

126 Kleinberg and Raghavan, 'Algorithmic Monoculture and Social Welfare'; Bommasani et al., 'Picking on the Same Person'.

of AI systems dominate. Rather than millions of individuals making decisions independently, an increasing share of those decisions could be mediated by the same underlying models and design choices.

Pushed to its extreme, a world in which a small number of AI agents mediate most decisions about what people consume — whether information, experiences, or products — risks suppressing the diversity of tastes, preferences, and cultural expression that make up a pluralistic society. This does not require every person to receive the same recommendation. A narrowing of the range of recommendations, choices and behaviors produced across society, generated by the same small set of underlying systems, is sufficient.

The homogenizing effects of dominant algorithmic systems can also extend beyond consumption to shape production. Cultural production itself, including music, films, and art, is already being tailored for algorithmic delivery.[127] Platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, TikTok, Netflix, and Spotify[128] each mediate particular domains of cultural consumption, creating the potential for algorithmically reinforced patterns of taste and production within those domains.

What distinguishes agentic AI, however, is the scope of what it may end up mediating. Where TikTok, YouTube, and Spotify are all generally bound by the domain in which they operate, the vision for agentic AI is an assistant that mediates the user's interaction with a theoretically infinite set of domains. As explained in this report, AI agents are poised to manage our information diets, provide advice, draft, and send communications, make purchases, assist with financial decisions, and perform other everyday tasks on our behalf.

If increasingly consequential decisions are mediated by the same small number of dominant models, convergence in how people perceive, respond, and act in the world could reduce the diversity of thought and action on which innovation, culture, social progress, and democratic politics depend.

This is not a purely hypothetical danger: a study of 21 state-of-the-art LLMs found that the models exhibited substantially less variation in their preferences than humans.[129] As these same foundation models underpin agentic AI, their widespread use could narrow the range of advice and actions produced across society. If one or a small number of such models were used by billions of people, the homogenization of AI-mediated recommendations and actions would have systemic, and likely harmful, consequences.

Economic harms

Agents are set to become intermediaries not just for information and decision-making, but also for economic activities including buying and selling products and services, making financial investments, searching and applying for jobs. They could either reduce friction and enable new connections, or distort the market by warping supply and demand.

If agentic platforms gain concentrated market power like that of today's tech intermediaries, they too will almost certainly follow the same playbook of abusing market power for commercial gain — from self-preferencing their own products and bullying small businesses, to suppressing innovation and extracting economic rents.

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127 Tavlin, 'Casual Viewing'.

128 The homogenizing influence of algorithmic platforms is complex and varies. In musical taste, streaming appears to have helped, rather than hindered, the growth of vibrant national patterns of musical consumption and production: Page and Dalla Riva, *'Glocalisation' of Music Streaming within and across Europe*.

129 Zhang et al., 'Cultivating Pluralism In Algorithmic Monoculture: The Community Alignment Dataset'.

Furthermore, the opacity of agentic systems, combined with their capacity for acting as well as advising, introduces new risks of dangerous correlated behavior and harmful algorithmic collusion.

Market steering and self-preferencing

Big Tech firms have an extensive and well-documented history of unfairly leveraging their monopolies to benefit their own products over those of commercial partners. Google exploits its dominance in search to steer users toward its own comparison-shopping service.[130] Similarly, Amazon uses its control over its marketplace to give preferential placement to its own retail offers and to sellers using Amazon's logistics services, as well as displays sponsored products that are nearly indistinguishable from organic results.[131]

The rise of agentic AI will not only multiply the opportunities for such behavior but simultaneously make it harder to detect and prove. Given the extreme vertical integration of today's tech giants, the potential for conflicts of interest extends across much of the digital economy. Google Gemini Spark could direct users toward Google Flights and Google Shopping, or prioritize Pixel phones in its product recommendations. Microsoft Copilot could steer users toward LinkedIn and GitHub, or favor Azure-hosted services and Microsoft 365 integrations over functionally equivalent competitors. Meta Muse, meanwhile, may favor Facebook Marketplace over competitors. Rivals are likely to find themselves at a systemic yet imperceptible disadvantage due not to the quality of their products, but to the architecture of the agent users have entrusted with their decisions.

As discussed earlier in this report, advertising is an emerging — and still contested — business model for consumer AI agents. Given the nature of agents, advertising creates strong incentives for AI firms to steer users toward providers of products and services they have struck commercial deals with. The most straightforward version of this would involve agentic assistants favoring partnered brands in recommendations or automated purchases. A luggage company that has paid for placement, for instance, would find its products surfaced ahead of competitors when a user asks for a recommendation or delegates the purchase entirely to their agent.

A more sophisticated version might involve higher-level partnership arrangements, in which an agentic developer strikes a deal with a travel booking platform that automatically routes all travel-related tasks through that business. In competitive markets, exclusive arrangements of this kind are a familiar if contentious commercial practice. In a concentrated market, where a small number of AI agents mediate an ever-growing share of consumer decisions, they risk gravely undermining autonomy, choice, and competition not through any action a person can observe or contest, but through invisible preferences built into the system they rely on.

More broadly, agents can steer users towards merchants that participate in the agentic provider's commercial infrastructure. OpenAI, for instance, is actively developing such an ecosystem. In February 2026, it launched "Instant Checkout", allowing merchants to provide product details to be featured in ChatGPT responses and process purchases directly in the chat interface,[132] or develop apps for users to use within ChatGPT.[133] While any merchant's content can theoretically still be included in chat responses, those that have

130 European Commission, 'Commission Fines Google €2.42 Billion'.

131 Federal Trade Commission, 'Amazon.com, Inc. (Amazon eCommerce)'.

132 OpenAI, 'Powering Product Discovery in ChatGPT'; OpenAI, 'Instant Checkout for Merchants in ChatGPT'.

133 OpenAI, 'Introducing Apps in ChatGPT and the New Apps SDK'.

built-in integrations and partnerships benefit from structured presentation, facilitated purchase processes, and may be prioritized in responses and actions.

Steering is also possible at the protocol layer. This dynamic has already played out in search: Google gave preferential placement to publishers that adopted its proprietary AMP framework (see earlier discussion), effectively forcing them to rebuild their pages on Google's terms or face being buried in search results.[134]

The very same risk is present in the agent market. As was explained above, Google is developing both one of the leading agentic assistants in the form of Gemini and one of the leading agentic commerce protocols in Universal Commerce Protocol (UCP). It can dictate which products are surfaced to consumers using its agentic assistant, favoring merchants that adopt its standards and excluding those that do not, thereby driving uptake of its protocol.

Surveillance Pricing

Surveillance pricing refers to the use of pervasive online tracking to tailor prices to individual consumers, a practice bringing retailers closer to their pipe dream of charging each buyer the maximum they are willing to pay. Thanks to their intimate access to personal data combined with their ability to build up trust over time through anthropomorphic design and behavior, agentic assistants are likely to be highly effective at ascertaining the maximum price consumers are willing to pay for products and services.

Amazon conducted early personalized pricing experiments in 2000, running a six-day trial charging consumers different prices for DVDs based on their purchasing history.[135] It apologized following a consumer backlash. While today Amazon denies tailoring prices to individual customers, and its opaque pricing algorithms make it difficult to prove such conduct, evidence suggests the existence of personalized pricing on its marketplace,[136] as does the FTC's 2023 lawsuit against it.[137]

Attempts at surveillance pricing have intensified in recent years.[138] A 2023 study cited by the U.S. Federal Trade Commission found that grocery stores already personalize prices at the zip code level, with algorithms triggering multiple price changes per day.[139] In Europe, the Dutch Authority for Consumers and Markets found that e-commerce platform Wish was personalizing prices based on consumers' location and purchasing decisions without disclosure.[140]

Agents threaten to make surveillance pricing both much easier, more effective, and more nefarious. Currently, effective surveillance pricing requires collating data from different data sources, cookies, and devices. An agent collapses this into a single source with direct, continuous visibility into the user's behavior, preferences, and state of mind thanks to access to

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134 Open Markets Institute, 'The Center for Journalism & Liberty at Open Markets Urges DOJ to Break Google's Search Monopoly and Address AI Risks'.

135 Chang and Chakrabarti, 'Will "Surveillance Pricing" Help or Harm Consumers?'

136 OECD, *Personalised Pricing in the Digital Era*. Mitchell, 'How Amazon's AI Algorithms Raise the Prices You Pay'. Wang et al., 'Algorithms, Artificial Intelligence, and Simple Rule-Based Pricing'.

137 Skipworth, 'Amazon Allegedly Used Secret Algorithm To Raise Prices On Consumers, FTC Lawsuit Reveals'.

138 Federal Trade Commission, *Issue Spotlight: The Rise of Surveillance Pricing*.

139 Aparicio et al., 'The Pricing Strategies of Online Grocery Retailers'.

140 Kimia Heidary, 'Personalised Pricing Is Happening'.

their chat logs, emails, browsing, and spending habits, physical location, calendar appointments, and more.

Agentic assistants can also infer emotional state, financial circumstances, and sensitive characteristics (ethnicity, sexual orientation, political views) from interaction patterns and use this to adjust prices accordingly. Users could be charged more when an agent ascertains an urgent need, such as for medication or last-minute travel. An agent may recommend or even directly purchase a premium product or subscription — or increase the price — after its user gets paid, or after they vent about a stressful week. Agents may also tailor how they present products to individual users by targeting specific preferences and vulnerabilities. Though hypothetical, these threats are not far-fetched: both the commercial incentives and the technological capabilities to exploit them already exist.

Surveillance pricing is a risk even without the agent's developer engaging in it. If granular user data collected by agentic AI is sold to third parties, they could use it to set personalized prices or terms themselves. A hotel platform or airline might for instance be able to buy data from an AI agent provider that empowers them to distinguish between travellers who urgently need to make a booking — for instance for a funeral — and travellers who are more flexible, charging a much higher price to the former.

It is currently impossible to audit agentic AI recommendations. Without real transparency and accountability requirements for agentic assistants, the potential for manipulation will be acute while the ability to prove surveillance pricing, illegal steering, or self-preferencing will remain impossible.

As with market steering, the opacity of agentic assistants makes surveillance pricing difficult to detect. Furthermore, when the agent is doing the shopping at the user's behest, there is no opportunity to comparison shop or seek a better price elsewhere.

Such practices are particularly problematic when consumers have a limited choice of providers. In the absence of competitive pressure or transparency and accountability requirements, suppliers of AI agents have the ability and incentive to extract maximum economic value from their users.

Gatekeeper power

Gatekeepers emerge when a platform becomes an intermediating channel between two or more groups that want to interact with each other. Agentic AI is poised to play that role across a wide swath of the global economy. If one or a handful of AI agents secure gatekeeper positions, they will be in a position to coerce, unfairly compete against, and extract value from businesses that depend on them to reach customers.

Apple has used its monopoly position as the sole distribution channel for apps on iOS devices to charge developers extortionate commissions since the App Store's launch in 2008. If OpenAI or any other actor is successful in securing agentic AI dominance, a similar dynamic is the most likely outcome. This has been the clear trend in other concentrated digital markets. Amazon's effective commission rate for third-party sellers on its Marketplace reached an estimated 45% in 2023, up from 19% in 2014 as its market share grew from roughly 22% to roughly 40%.[141] These commissions erode the profitability and ultimately the viability of large swathes of businesses, and in many cases are passed onto consumers through higher prices, as the FTC already alleges in its ongoing antitrust lawsuit against Amazon.[142]

E-commerce was singled out early on as a sector ripe for agentic AI intermediation: by severing the

141 Mitchell, 'Amazon's Monopoly Tollbooth in 2023'; Tabuchi, 'It's Amazon and Also-Rans in Retailers' Race for Online Sales'; Emarketer, 'Amazon Accounted for 40% of Ecommerce Sales, 4% of Retail Sales in 2023'.

142 Federal Trade Commission, 'FTC Sues Amazon for Illegally Maintaining Monopoly Power'.

relationship between buyers and sellers, both consumers and businesses become subject to the whims of AI gatekeepers. According to McKinsey estimates, global commercial retail could see $3 trillion to $5 trillion in revenue flowing through agentic-AI-mediated commerce by 2030. This is a meaningful share of global economic output, and an attractive target for monopoly control.[143] OpenAI's early attempt to capture that market, Instant Checkout, charged retailers a 4% sales commission.[144] Though that particular initiative floundered, it is indicative of agentic AI's gatekeeping potential: Meta's integration of Facebook Marketplace directly into its Muse agent is indicative of that belief.[145]

Because agentic assistants promise to gatekeep access to consumers across multiple industries simultaneously, even large retailers with diverse product lines risk becoming dependent on a single or small set of firms. But the potential harms go beyond extracting commissions. Amazon has long used the power of its search algorithm to benefit its own bottom line at the expense of independent sellers. It has tied use of its logistics and paid advertising services to search rankings; downranked sellers offering lower prices outside of its marketplace; and used its access to platform data to copy successful third-party offerings, whether physical products[146] or software services,[147] before boosting those copies in search results.[148]

Leading AI firms are already engaging in similar behavior, leveraging their market power to deploy copycat tactics. Anthropic for instance, having initially partnered with Canva and Figma to integrate their services into its agentic assistant, ended up creating its own competing service, which it then integrated into its core offering.[149] It is naïve not to expect that successful apps or integrations built on AI gatekeepers' infrastructure will be copied and unfairly disadvantaged in this way, losing out not because they were worse, but because of an unassailable power imbalance.

Both Anthropic and OpenAI have also abruptly cut off potential competitors' access to their models. OpenAI did so after it was announced Cursor would be acquired by xAI in August 2026.[150] Similarly, Anthropic ended AI coding tool Windsurf's direct access to Claude models with under five days' notice, while other AI coding platforms kept their access, after rumors emerged that it would be acquired by OpenAI.[151]

When AI assistants manage grocery lists, plan trips, and suggest or buy Christmas gifts, supermarkets, airlines, clothing brands, and booksellers alike will have no choice but to reach their clients through agentic platforms. While a competitive market would allow them the autonomy to use multiple providers, a concentrated one will lock them in with no choice but to pay the monopoly rent and be subject to the whims of the gatekeeper's rules.

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143 Philipp Kluge et al., 'AI-Powered e-Commerce: Boost Sales with Agentic Shopping'.

144 The Information, 'ChatGPT Checkouts to Take 4% Cut of Shopify Merchant Sales'.

145 Weatherbed, 'Meta's Muse AI Sent a YouTuber's Address to a Stranger'.

146 *Reuters*, 'Amazon Copied Products and Rigged Search Results, Documents Show'.

147 Claburn, 'Amazon Elasticsearch Service Is so Flexible It Wants to Be Called by a New Name'.

148 Federal Trade Commission, 'FTC Sues Amazon for Illegally Maintaining Monopoly Power'.

149 Palazzolo and Efrati, 'Anthropic Blindsides Its Business Partners'.

150 OpenAI, 'Our Decision on Cursor Following Its Acquisition by SpaceX'.

151 Zeff, 'Windsurf Says Anthropic Is Limiting Its Direct Access to Claude AI Models'.

Correlated agent behavior

When millions of consumers rely on the same agentic provider, their agents share the same underlying foundation model, the same training data, and the same decision-making logic. This means that when these agents encounter an external event, they are likely to respond in similar or identical ways, and at similar or identical speeds. In certain contexts, correlated algorithmic behavior can have catastrophic consequences. This was the case for the 2010 Flash Crash, a 36-minute $1 trillion stock market crash triggered by a feedback loop between similar automated trading algorithms that responded to the same market signals with the same logic, turning a sell-off into a near-instantaneous collapse.[152]

With retail trading platforms such as Robinhood[153] opening their services to agentic AI systems, users can now relatively easily set up automated trading. If a critical mass of these users rely on the same underlying AI model — exposed to the same news, reasoning with the same logic, and executing at the same speed — an event on the scale of the Flash Crash becomes more likely, and potentially even a regular occurrence. A market signal interpreted uniformly across thousands or even millions of AI-managed portfolios could trigger a wave of simultaneous buying or selling decisions that no single human actor would be able to interrupt.

The risks of such correlated behavior go well beyond financial markets. Mass identical responses to major news events, supply shocks and public safety scares, already highly disruptive when they occur, have the potential to become much more common and significant through widespread adoption of AI agents. If large numbers of agents simultaneously conclude that users should purchase particular goods, cancel travel plans, switch energy suppliers, or avoid certain locations, the cumulative effect would be massively disruptive. The panic buying that took place in the early days of the Covid-19 pandemic showed how problematic these events can be, even without the involvement of AI.

Centralized points of failure

As people and businesses come to rely on AI agents for a rapidly expanding set of essential activities, from banking and shopping to travel and healthcare, a concentrated market would create dangerous new vulnerabilities. If a dominant agent provider suffers an outage or is subject to a cyberattack, millions of people and organizations could simultaneously lose access to a technology they have built personal lives and critical systems around.

Many AI assistants and agents are granted access to an extraordinary quantity of sensitive data and systems.[154] This includes not only information relating to bank accounts, social security, medical records, emails, messaging, photos, and purchase histories, but the power and permission to act on that information by making payments, planning appointments, and sending messages. A single security failure in such highly concentrated digital infrastructure can have global effects, as several recent incidents have demonstrated.[155]

A similar incident affecting an agentic system used extensively by millions or even billions of people could have catastrophic consequences. Though failures of this kind can happen to any provider regardless of market concentration, greater market diversity reduces the magnitude of harm: fewer people and businesses are exposed by any single incident.

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152 Kirilenko et al., 'The Flash Crash'.

153 Shah and Steer, 'Robinhood to Let Investors Use AI Chatbots for Share Trading'.

154 Constantinescu, '135K OpenClaw AI Agents Exposed to Internet'.

155 Analytics Insight, 'Google Confirms 2.5B Gmail Users Caught in Massive Data Breach'.

Prompt injection attacks — in which malicious instructions are embedded in content an agent is asked to process, hijacking its advice or actions — already represent a serious cybersecurity threat.[156] In a concentrated market, the systemic consequences of a successful large-scale prompt injection campaign are vastly amplified: a single exploited vulnerability in a systemically large provider could simultaneously compromise the accounts, data, and real-world actions of hundreds of millions of users.[157] Diversity of provision is therefore not merely a competition policy question but a matter of systemic resilience.

A simple hypothetical illustrates the danger. Imagine a future in which e-commerce is predominantly mediated by AI agents. Consumers make purchases, compare prices, and manage returns through a single agentic AI system, while businesses rely on the same infrastructure to manage inventory, predict sales, process transactions, and reach customers. In such a world, a single outage at a dominant provider would not merely inconvenience users: it would simultaneously freeze both sides of the market. Buyers would lose the ability to transact; sellers would lose access to their customers. The economic cost would be staggering. Amazon's 2021 AWS outage — which lasted less than a day and took down Amazon's own retail operation alongside large parts of the broader internet — is estimated to have cost billions of dollars in lost commerce.[158] An equivalent failure in a world built around a dominant agentic assistant would be of a different order of magnitude and affect far more than just e-commerce.

Algorithmic collusion

Concerns about algorithmic collusion long predate the arrival of LLMs. In 2011, a price war between two competing Amazon sellers' pricing bots erupted over a biology book. Stuck in a feedback loop, "The Making of a Fly" ended up listed by both at over $23 million, the first vivid public illustration that automated pricing systems can interact in ways no human intended or predicted.[159]

There have been many other cases since then. In 2025, 26 property management firms using RealPage's algorithmic pricing software paid out $142 million to settle a class action lawsuit alleging they had engaged in algorithmic collusion. More specifically, they were accused of feeding non-public, confidential rent and occupancy data into RealPage's revenue management software, which then generated shared pricing recommendations that allowed landlords to coordinate rent increases across the multifamily housing market.[160]

There are real concerns that the rapid expansion of LLM-based agentic AI will open the door to further — and potentially worse — opportunities for algorithmic collusion. Research has already confirmed that LLM-based pricing agents have the capacity to collude and may do so faster than reinforcement learning approaches.[161]

But the risks associated with algorithmic collusion are not exclusively limited to collusion between AI agents. In addition to businesses using AI to collude amongst themselves, widespread consumer adoption of AI agents — particularly a small number of agents —could also facilitate algorithmic collusion.

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156 Huang, 'Prompt Injection in AI'.

157 OWASPGenAIProject, 'LLM012025 Prompt Injection'.

158 AWS in Plain English, 'The Biggest AWS Outage in History'.

159 Solon, 'How A Book About Flies Came To Be Priced $24 Million On Amazon'.

160 Freshfields, 'Key Development in the Algorithmic Collusion Saga'.

161 Fish et al., 'Algorithmic Collusion by Large Language Models'; Callaci and Vaheesan, 'The Market Alone Can't Fix the U.S. Housing Crisis'.

Algorithmic collusion in a concentrated agentic assistant market may emerge in the following ways:

Tacit algorithmic collusion between agents and third parties

When a consumer instructs their agent to take an action, and that agent interacts directly with third-party systems, aligned incentives can result in algorithmic collusion. For instance, an agent which earns a commission on sales may interact directly with a third party's pricing or recommendation algorithm to procure a product or service. Over time, these interacting systems may learn to coordinate their behavior by aligning pricing, ranking, or negotiation strategies in ways that reduce competitive pressure and increase profits for the firms involved, despite the absence of any explicit communication or agreement. Such tacit coordination emerges from algorithmic optimization and repeated interaction rather than human intent.

Seller-side reinforcement via predictable buyers

When millions of consumers route purchases through the same few agents, seller pricing algorithms get a stable, legible signal to learn from, making tacit price alignment among sellers easier to sustain. The fewer and/or more homogeneous the agents, the easier algorithmic collusion becomes for sellers' pricing algorithms. This does not require any collusion by the agents — instead, it is the use of similar or identical agents by buyers that simplifies algorithmic collusion.

Buy-side concentration due to algorithmic monoculture (reverse "hub and spoke")

A third form of algorithmic collusion may emerge to the detriment of sellers, with tacit collusion among buyer agents generating a monopsony-like dynamic. The more homogenous agents are (due to market concentration or design convergence), the more likely they are to independently converge on similar negotiating tactics, similar willingness-to-pay thresholds, or similar merchant preferences. This may produce buyer-side coordination across a huge pool of demand with no explicit agreement anywhere.

The global struggle to govern AI

The concentration of AI power is increasingly recognized as a global problem, catapulting it to the top of the international agenda. The United Nations has documented persistent global power asymmetries in technological capacity, market power, and participation in AI governance. The UN's Global Digital Compact states that equitable and meaningful inclusion in the digital economy "requires tackling existing concentrations of technological capacity and market power".[162]

Yet the fact that the underlying infrastructure of AI remains highly concentrated in a handful of corporations and even fewer countries is fundamentally at odds with the need for inclusive governance, capacity-building, and technical harmonization. According to UN Trade and Development, 100 firms, mainly in the United States and China, account for 40 percent of global corporate R&D spending, and 118 countries, mostly in the Global South, are absent from major AI governance discussions.[163] The 2026 Global Dialogue on AI Governance identified persistent divides in "infrastructure, connectivity, computing power, data, skills and institutional capacity" as the concern raised most consistently across regions.[164]

The result is global dependency on the same dominant players even in venues designed to represent diverse national interests. As multilateral bodies attempt to establish standards, protocols, or safety frameworks for AI agents, they rely on the technical knowledge and resources of those companies and their leaders, as the lineup of Silicon Valley tech executives at high-level UN AI processes underscores, while neglecting questions of power.

162 United Nations, UN Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance, Co-Chairs' Summary.

163 UNCTAD, *Inclusive Artificial Intelligence for Development*.

164 United Nations, 'Opening Sessions - Global Dialogue on Artificial Intelligence Governance - Day 1'.

Recommendations

As we have seen, consolidation of power around a handful of agentic gatekeepers would pose a broad set of harms to our political and economic liberties, likely surpassing those seen in today's already highly concentrated digital economy.

The difference with agentic AI is that policymakers still have time to pre-empt these dangers. Despite the growing power of a small number of AI firms, the market and core technologies underlying AI agents remain in flux, with standards, inputs, business models, and infrastructure still being established.

Policymakers are already taking steps in the right direction. This includes U.S. Senator Mark Warner's proposed AI AGENTS Act, which introduces duties of loyalty, interoperability requirements, and privacy protections for the agentic AI market, and several ongoing enforcement actions by the European Commission which seek to maintain a level playing field for different AI agents.[165]

By acting now, governments can minimize harm and ensure that agentic AI serves to empower citizens, businesses, and creators, instead of exploiting and disenfranchising them.

Summary of recommendations

Fiduciary-style duties

- Binding duty of care requiring agents to act in users' interests
- Mandatory conflict-of-interest disclosures
- Rebuttable presumption of disloyalty (burden on agentic providers to disprove)
- Ban on exploiting sensitive user data for commercial gain

Same activity, same rules

- Agents held to the same standards (if not the same rules) as human professionals for regulated advice and tasks in parallel or regulated domains
- Clear avenues for users to obtain redress for harms

Limiting surveillance

- Limit data collection to purpose and necessity; restrict collection of sensitive data including biometric, cognitive, and neural data; time-limit data retention
- User rights and ability to view and delete data and "memory" held by agents
- Require low or no-data product options
- Extend "no-training" protections to individuals as well as businesses

Securing a competitive market

- Vertical interoperability: fair access to underlying platforms and services (email, calendars, OS, platforms)
- Horizontal interoperability: portable data (history, preferences, documents) between providers; seamless re-integration on switching

165 'Warner Unveils Discussion Draft of Legislation to Create Innovative Market for Secure Artificial Intelligence Agents'.

- Fair, reasonable, and non-discriminatory access to dominant platforms and dominant agents

Competition policy

- Deploy agile antitrust enforcement to stop anti-competitive practices in the agentic market, including by using injunctions and interim measures
- Block anti-competitive mergers and acquisitions that relate to agentic AI, including in adjacent markets (chips, cloud, devices)
- Treat minority investments, partnerships, and acquihires in AI markets as de facto mergers where warranted
- Monitor and where necessary block or unwind problematic partnerships and investments between AI agent providers and businesses in other sectors of the economy
- Structural remedies: mandate divestments or line-of-business restrictions (e.g. separate cloud from AI) to neutralize conflicts of interest and deconcentrate power

Algorithmic collusion

- Rebuttable presumption of collusion for systematically anti-competitive algorithmic outcomes, plus audit and logging requirements
- Restrict use of non-public competitor data in pricing and ranking decisions
- Grant regulators audit access to test algorithms for collusive behavior

Ensuring agents act in the interests of their users, not their owners

While agents could in theory give people greater agency in navigating the online world, in practice they are more likely to become tools of corporate surveillance and manipulation, particularly in the context of today's concentrated digital economy. This raises the question of how, and whether, agents can be made to act in the interests of their users, rather than the corporations that own and control them.

A recent Open Markets Institute report, *Who Do AI Agents Work For*, written by Sally Hubbard, outlines several steps that governments could take to rebalance power between agents and people, while acknowledging that these are unlikely to be fully effective without complementary measures to rebalance power within the digital economy itself.[166]

Imposing fiduciary-style duties

While the term "agent" implies responsibility and loyalty towards the user, in practice we should expect AI agents to promote first and foremost the financial interests of their corporate owners, particularly when there is money to be made by steering users towards specific content, products or actions, including by taking those actions on their behalf. This applies particularly to Big Tech firms, which have extensive business interests beyond agents, and which have a long history of manipulating and exploiting people and businesses for commercial ends.

166 Hubbard, 'Who Do AI Agents Work For?'

Against this backdrop, it is relevant to explore whether agentic providers could be made subject to a binding duty of care that would legally oblige them to act in their users' interests. Common law jurisdictions including the United Kingdom and the United States have a specific category of legal duty that governs relationships where a party undertakes to act as an agent for another, known as a "fiduciary duty". Though not present in civil law jurisdictions, including much of Europe, similar duties based on similar principles exist in these places as well.[167]

In addition to a basic duty requiring agents to act in their users' interests, there are several other ways that this could be reinforced,[168] including:

- A requirement to disclose material conflicts of interest (such as commercial affiliation with a specific product) so that the user can make an informed choice about whether to use an agent for a particular task.
- A rebuttable "presumption of disloyalty" requiring agent providers to prove to regulators that they are not promoting their own commercial interests over those of their users. This is important given the opacity of current systems.
- A requirement to refrain from exploiting sensitive information about the user for commercial gain, such as knowledge about a person's finances, sexual orientation, or health.

A fundamental question is whether such legal duties are compatible with business models that profit from surveillance, addiction, manipulation, and extraction, activities that are fundamentally misaligned with people's interests and the public good. While not all AI agents will be controlled by tech giants with such toxic business models, many — if not the majority — will, raising difficult questions about how such duties can be enforced.

What is clear is that fiduciary-style duties and other similar regulation will only be truly effective in an agentic market where power is widely dispersed, and where people are able to easily switch between providers.

Requiring comparable regulation for comparable activities

It is essential that AI agents are held to the same standards as human agents when they take comparable actions on behalf of their users. Already, AI agents and assistants are giving people sensitive advice on topics that they may otherwise have turned to human experts for, including advice on personal finance, healthcare, career decisions, and intimate relationships. Allowing AI agents to provide such recommendations — and in some cases act on them — without the regulatory responsibilities their human counterparts comply with risks exposing people to inaccurate, misguided, or dangerous advice while giving technology an unfair advantage over human labor.

When agents provide advice or take actions that would be regulated if carried out by a licensed professional (for example filing taxes, claiming government benefits, recommending investment products, providing health-related advice), they should be held to the same legal standards as the professionals that carry out those tasks are.[169] Importantly, general purpose agents should also be held to the same standards as more specialized tools, such as an AI tool designed specifically for filing taxes, if they provide the same or similar services. This will ensure that specialized tools aren't at an unfair disadvantage and foster a more diverse market of agentic and non-agentic AI tools. In case of harms caused by AI agent's advice or actions, users must have straightforward ways to claim redress from the companies that own and operate them.

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167 Gelter and Helleringer, 'Fiduciary Principles in European Civil Law Systems'.

168 Kolt, 'Governing AI Agents'.

169 Jess Rapson et al., 'A G7 Strategy for AI Competition and Consumer Rights'.

Limiting invasive surveillance

While some degree of personalization, and thus data collection, is needed if AI agents are to be useful to their users, this should be strictly limited to what is necessary for providing the service in question, rather than what accumulates the most power and profit for the corporation behind the agent. That means limiting the amount of data that AI agents are allowed to collect in the first place, limiting what they can do with that data once they've collected it, and requiring them to delete the data as soon as it is no longer needed, or store it locally on a users device for their use only. Directly collecting or indirectly inferring sensitive data, such as data relating to people's ethnicity, sexual orientation, political opinions, health status, or genetic background, should be off limits, or only allowed under tightly specified conditions.

People should also be empowered to scrutinize the data that agents collect or infer from them in an accessible way, and to delete such data where they are uncomfortable with its collection, storage, and analysis. Providers of AI agents should be required to offer versions of their products that require little to no personal data to function, and potentially even to offer these as the default. Safeguards that are already common for enterprise AI agents could also be extended to individual users, such as contractual provisions preventing AI agents from using customer prompts to train and tune AI models.[170]

Existing privacy laws including the European Union's General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) already embody many of these principles and could be applied to limit surveillance by AI agents. However, these rules, especially the GDPR, have been significantly underenforced, and have so far failed to counter Big Tech's surveillance machines.

Creating an effective market for AI agents

While necessary, rules requiring providers of AI agents to behave in certain ways, or to refrain from certain harmful practices, will have limited impact if people are locked into using specific agents. Unless each individual user has the practical (not just theoretical) ability to leave, agentic providers will have little incentive to put users' interests first, including by complying with laws requiring them to do so.

In this section, we identify the mechanisms needed to create a functioning market for AI agents, including vertical and horizontal interoperability, data portability, and non-discriminatory access requirements.

Vertical interoperability

Vertical interoperability is needed to ensure that agents have fair access to the third-party services they need to offer recommendations and take actions, such as email, calendars, messaging apps, operating systems, and productivity tools, without being locked out by dominant platforms.

Regulators in Europe are already taking steps to make the AI market interoperable by imposing interoperability obligations on gatekeepers that control operating systems, virtual assistants, and related hardware and software features. In July 2026, the European Commission issued measures under the Digital Markets Act (DMA) requiring Google to give rival AI services fair access to the Android features that Gemini already enjoys full use of.[171] The Commission has also forced Meta to reverse contractual changes that cut off rival AI assistants' access to WhatsApp.

While it remains to be seen how effective these specific interventions will be, similar measures should be applied to all dominant tech firms that control infrastructure, platforms, or services that independent AI agents need to

170 King et al., 'User Privacy and Large Language Models'; Christakis, 'You Trust Your Chatbot With Everything. Should You?'

171 European Commission, 'Commission Opens Proceedings to Assist Google in Complying with Interoperability and Online Search Data Sharing Obligations under the Digital Markets Act'.

be effective. This is particularly important when Big Tech firms offer their own agents, given the incentives this gives them to self-preference their own services and exclude rivals. Instead of going after one dominant firm at a time, regulators should seek to introduce generalized principles and obligations that apply across firms and access points.

One way of achieving this is by requiring platforms to provide open, standardized interfaces through which third-party agents can access their services. Such interfaces are already emerging. The Model Context Protocol (MCP), now governed by the Linux Foundation, allows AI agents to interact with external software services through a single open standard, rather than requiring bespoke integrations with each platform.[172]

Given the large amounts of data that AI agents and other tech services have access to, this must be done carefully and in ways that protect individual privacy and autonomy, without letting gatekeepers determine what the right balance looks like. While there is at times a genuine trade-off to make between privacy and competition, this should be determined by independent experts, regulators, and legal regimes, not the commercial interests of dominant corporations.

Horizontal interoperability and data portability

In addition to mandating vertical interoperability, regulators must also impose horizontal interoperability so that users can freely switch between different agents without being trapped by the data and integrations they have built up over time.

As agentic assistants build up detailed knowledge of their users over time, and build themselves into their daily lives and habits, the costs of switching will grow, leaving consumers vulnerable to exploitation and erecting barriers to competitors. To combat this, regulations must ensure that users can easily move their data between agent providers. This must include conversation and transaction history, user preferences (including any that were inferred by the agent), and any documents shared with the agent. Users should be able to request all this information in a standardized, machine-readable format. Regulators must also ensure that users can seamlessly re-integrate services such as email, calendars, and social media when switching providers so that the process is not laborious or time consuming.

In doing so, policymakers should learn from recent efforts to mandate interoperability in other parts of the technology stack, many of which are also highly relevant to AI. Under laws including the EU's DMA and Data Act, European regulators have introduced horizontal interoperability requirements for cloud computing and instant messaging services, and are considering similar measures in social media.

Fair, reasonable, and non-discriminatory access

Interoperability alone will not prevent dominant tech platforms from unfairly discriminating against actual or potential AI rivals. For example, a Big Tech firm could offer an API to third-party agents while still giving its own agent faster response times, richer data, or more favorable terms.

To address this, dominant tech platforms should be subject to fair, reasonable, and non-discriminatory (FRAND) access obligations, a principle already well established in European regulation of the energy, transport, telecommunications sectors, and more recently in digital markets as well. In the case of agents, this would require dominant platforms to provide all agents with access on equal terms, regardless of ownership, competitive rivalry, or other commercial considerations.

These obligations must also extend to agents themselves. As we have argued in this report, as agents increasingly intermediate between consumers and businesses, they could come to occupy a gatekeeping position analogous to

172 Though MCP remains open and stewarded by a third party in the form of the Linux Foundation, it is important to note that the Foundation has long been criticized for favoring the interests and priorities of its highest-paying members: Big Tech, see e.g. Hall, 'The Linux Foundation'.

and potentially even greater than that of today's tech giants. These obligations should require dominant agents to offer equal access to all businesses that rely on them to access customers, and prevent them from arbitrarily restricting the visibility of merchants, publishers, or other service providers.

Third-party certification

Dominant platforms will need to ensure that agents accessing their services meet certain safety standards. However, it should not be left up to these platforms to decide which agents qualify as safe, especially when many large platforms have their own commercial interests in the agentic AI.

The Amazon-Perplexity and Amazon-Meta disputes illustrate this tension. Amazon has sued to block Perplexity's AI-agent browser Comet from accessing its marketplace, labeling it an "intruder" and citing cybersecurity risks to its customers.[173] More recently, it has also blocked Meta's Muse agent from shopping on Amazon.com on behalf of customers, after attempting unsuccessfully to get Meta to voluntarily exclude its site.[174] Even if these security concerns prove to be well-founded, the case highlights a fundamental conflict of interest. Amazon's terms of service reserve "sole discretion" to refuse access to agents. This means that even if an agent is perfectly safe and secure, Amazon can still refuse access.

Independent third-party certification is needed to ensure that standards are set, monitored and enforced by a neutral public body instead of private gatekeepers. The UK's Open Banking framework offers a useful precedent. The Competition and Markets Authority (CMA) established an independent body to set technical and security standards governing third-party access to banking services, taking this power away from the incumbent banks. A similar independent body could be established to set security standards for AI agents, preventing dominant platforms from using safety as a pretext for exclusion.

Using competition policy to stop consolidation and (re)shape markets in the public interest

Tackling anti-competitive practices

As dominant platforms increasingly wield their market power to capture the agentic market, competition authorities must be prepared to use the full range of legal tools at their disposal to investigate, punish, remedy, and ideally prevent such conduct.

These tools include ex-post laws such as Article 102 of the European Union's Treaty on the Functioning of the EU (TFEU), the Sherman Act in the United States, Japan's Anti-Monopoly Act, and Brazil Competition Law (Nº 12.529). All seek to prevent large or dominant firms from abusing their market power and monopolizing markets. More recently, they have been joined by a growing number of ex-ante frameworks including the EU's Digital Markets Act (DMA), the UK's Digital Markets, Competition and Consumer Act (DMCCA), and similar proposals under consideration in Australia, India, and Brazil.

Compared to the past, competition authorities are showing greater willingness to intervene early — including through the use of injunctions and interim remedies — to prevent AI markets from "tipping" into the hands of gatekeepers.

In October 2025, Meta updated WhatsApp's Business terms to ban third-party AI assistants from the platform while continuing to push its own assistant onto users. Just one month later, the Italian competition authority filed for interim measures to suspend the unfair terms.[175] In early 2026, the European Commission followed with its own

173 CourtListener, 'Amazon.com Services LLC v. Perplexity AI, Inc., 3'.

174 Bishop, 'Amazon Blocks Meta's Muse AI Assistant in New Standoff over Agentic Shopping'.

175 AGCM, 'The Italian Competition Authority orders Meta to suspend the terms excluding competing AI Chatbots from WhatsApp'.

plans to impose interim measures, leading Meta to reverse the changes and allow rival chatbots access in Europe.[176]

In a similar vein, and as mentioned above, the Commission has also ordered Google to provide third-party AI services with the search data and operating system access they need to compete, to prevent Google from unfairly favoring its own services. In the UK, the CMA has intervened under the DMCCA to prevent Google from abusing its market power over publishers, including empowering the latter to opt out of having their content used to train Google's AI products.

These early interventions by regulators, while relatively modest, demonstrate how competition enforcement can be used to stop anti-competitive practices before — rather than after — they lead to irreversible monopolization. It is critical that competition authorities not only continue to take such measures but multiply and deepen their efforts significantly, given the speed with which dominant players are seeking to capture the AI market.

Blocking anti-competitive mergers and partnerships

One of the main ways that dominant firms reinforce their market power, particularly in the tech sector, is by acquiring existing or potential rivals. In some cases, this is motivated by a desire to secure exclusive access to a rival's assets or capabilities, whether that means an algorithm, valuable data, or specific expertise. In other cases, the goal is simply to eliminate the competition via what are often described as "killer acquisitions".[177] Whatever the motivation, competition authorities must closely monitor, and where necessary block, acquisitions likely to entrench the power of a handful of firms over critical AI technologies, including agents.

Last December, Meta acquired Chinese AI agent startup Manus, with the aim of using the startup's technology to deliver general purpose agents across its consumer and business products.[178] This fits a historical pattern of Meta acquiring nascent threats, already seen with WhatsApp and Instagram. The deal was subsequently blocked by the Chinese government, despite Meta already absorbing Manus into its business, albeit on national security rather than competition grounds. Regardless, the Manus example shows that regulators are more attuned to the risks of tech acquisitions than in the past. Several major tech mergers have been stopped by regulators over the past few years, including Nvidia/Arm, Adobe/Figma, Meta/Giphy and Amazon/iRobot.

Scrutiny should not be limited to mergers involving agentic AI providers. As this report has argued, power in the agentic market will ultimately be determined by control over relevant inputs and distribution channels including AI models, cloud computing, semiconductors, browsers, online platforms, and consumer devices. Competition authorities should therefore also monitor and where necessary prevent consolidation in these adjacent markets where this risks weakening competition, diversity, and choice in AI.

Partly in response to stricter merger control, dominant tech companies have begun using other strategies to influence, co-opt or control potential challengers, including acquiring minority equity stakes, signing (often one-sided) partnerships and poaching executive talent through so-called "reverse acquihires" (such as Google absorbing

176 European Commission, 'Commission Notifies Meta of Possible Interim Measures'.

177 Cunningham et al., 'Killer Acquisitions'.

178 Roach, 'Meta Faces China Probe over Acquisition of AI Agent Startup Manus'.

Windsurf executives,[179] the Scale AI team joining Meta,[180] and Nvidia acquiring much of startup Groq's talent and assets).[181] Dominant cloud providers Amazon, Google, and Microsoft and dominant chip designer Nvidia have struck many partnerships with leading AI startups. Microsoft owns 27% of OpenAI, which has also signed major cloud deals with both Amazon and Google.[182] Amazon has invested a total of $8 billion in Anthropic and serves as its primary cloud and training partner, while Google holds a 14% stake.[183]

These entanglements risk weakening competitive pressures in the agentic and wider AI and tech markets, creating incentives for explicit or tacit coordination on pricing, terms, distribution mechanisms, and even underlying business models (e.g. advertising-funded). They not only limit the ability and incentive of startups to challenge Big Tech firms, but anchor the entire paradigm of AI development around the narrow commercial interests and priorities of a handful of giants. Competition authorities should view such arrangements as de facto mergers and not hesitate to unwind them if necessary, whether under merger control or separate laws prohibiting anti-competitive cartels and agreements. If existing laws are not suited to the task, then they must urgently be updated.

Finally, authorities may increasingly need to monitor acquisitions, investments, and partnerships between tech firms and non-tech firms, such as in retail. As agentic assistants increasingly mediate how consumers discover and purchase goods and services across the economy, such financial relationships risk distorting the objectivity and reliability of the recommendations that users receive.

Using structural remedies to prevent conflicts of interest

Governments can and have used structural remedies such as divestments and line of business restrictions (LOBRs) to prevent dominant firms from unfairly leveraging their concentrated power into adjacent markets, and to rectify conflicts of interest arising from cross-ownership of different businesses and assets. These remedies can be imposed on firms after the fact as a way of stopping proven anti-competitive conduct, as in the case of the divestments sometimes required in antitrust and merger investigations. They can also be used as a preventative measure to stop firms from consolidating power across markets in the first place, such as in the case of LOBRs.

When it comes to AI agents, the role and relevance of structural remedies varies depending on which part of the stack you look at.

Structural measures may be needed to prevent AI firms from abusing their market power, for example, by using their agents to unfairly promote other businesses they own or those of favored partners. Regulators could either wait until such behavior becomes an obvious problem and then order the divestments needed to end it. Alternatively, they could use LOBRs to preemptively ban AI companies from operating in industries that present obvious conflicts of interest (which, given the universal nature of AI agents, is likely to be most of them), thus preventing the harmful conduct from arising in the first place. Which route is most effective will depend on how the market and technology develop.

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179 Srinivasaragavan, 'Google Hires Windsurf Heads in $2.4bn Licensing Deal'.

180 Heath, 'Meta Is Paying $14 Billion to Catch up in the AI Race'.

181 *Financial Times*, 'Nvidia's $20bn Licensing Deal with Groq Faces Lawsuit from Jilted Engineers'.

182 Microsoft, 'The next Chapter of the Microsoft—OpenAI Partnership'; Amazon, 'AWS and OpenAI Announce Multi-Year Strategic Partnership'; CNBC, 'OpenAI Taps Google in Unprecedented Cloud Deal despite AI Rivalry, Sources Say'.

183 Anthropic, 'Powering the next Generation of AI Development with AWS'; Metz et al., 'Inside Google's Investment in the A.I. Start-Up Anthropic'.

The case for structural remedies is even stronger as a means of neutralizing the advantages that Big Tech firms' existing monopolies give them in AI, including agentic AI. Divestments or LOBRs could be used to definitively prevent gatekeepers in other markets and technologies from unfairly leveraging their power into AI. For example, as the Open Markets Institute has argued in several reports, regulators should require Amazon, Google, and Microsoft to divest their cloud computing businesses, so that they cannot exploit these to gain an unfair advantage in AI and other technologies and sectors that depend on fair and non-discriminatory access to computing power.[184]

Structural separation could also be considered in relation to other inputs critical for AI agent development and deployment, including chips, foundation models, and operating systems. Going further, regulators could even consider prohibiting Big Tech firms from owning AI agents in the first place, given the difficulty — compared to standalone AI agents — of ensuring that Big Tech's agents put the interests of the user, as opposed to the corporation, first. As an alternative to full divestment, regulators could require Big Tech firms to create firewalls (legal, financial, technical, operational) between their agents and other business interests, although such "functional" separation has proven hard to monitor in the past, especially in digital markets.[185]

Thwarting algorithmic collusion

The laws and doctrines regulating collusion developed to address such behavior by humans, not automated systems. Collusion has historically required a meeting of human minds or an agreement between parties. Algorithms, by efficiently testing strategies and working with other automated systems to achieve their mutual goals, show that collusion can take place without it. This suggests that policies, laws, and enforcement practices designed to prevent illegal collusion among humans may need to be updated for the digital age.

A range of regulatory interventions could reduce the risks of algorithmic collusion. These include:

Introducing a presumption of collusion for algorithms that systematically distort competition: Where a pricing or ranking algorithm systematically distorts competition, the burden of proof could be shifted so that firms must demonstrate their algorithms are not engaged in illegal collusion, as opposed to regulators having to uncover it. This would need to be paired with mandatory auditing and logging obligations, so that firms cannot invoke automation itself as a liability shield.

Imposing restrictions on using data that enables algorithmic collusion: The strongest legislative proposal in this area to date, the U.S. Preventing Algorithmic Collusion Act, aims to prohibit pricing algorithms that rely on non-public competitor data. Regulators could similarly prohibit AI agents from using non-public data collected from business customers to inform the pricing, ranking, or promotion of that customer's competitors, preventing agents from being used to facilitate RealPage-style collusion scenarios.

Mandating computational audit access for regulators: Emerging technical proposals, such as calibrated-regret testing, a method that checks whether an algorithm's choices look like those of a system independently maximizing its own payoff,[186] offer regulators a way to assess whether an algorithm's observed behavior is consistent with independent optimization (as opposed to collusion). Mandating access for regulators to run this class of test against deployed pricing, ranking, or negotiation algorithms would give enforcement an early foothold in the battle against AI-enabled collusion.

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184 Max von Thun and George Colville, *Taming the Hyperscalers*; von Thun and Lavin, *Engineering the Cloud Commons: Tackling Monopoly Control of Critical Digital Infrastructure*.

185 Khan, 'The Separation of Platforms and Commerce', 1083–85; Kwoka and Moss, 'Behavioral Merger Remedies'.

186 Hartline et al., 'Regulation of Algorithmic Collusion'; Hartline et al., 'Regulation of Algorithmic Collusion, Refined'.

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